

Resource: Tyndale Open Study Notes

Aquifer Open Study Notes

This work is an adaptation of Tyndale Open Study Notes © 2023 Tyndale House Publishers, licensed under the CC BY-SA 4.0 license. The adaptation, Aquifer Open Study Notes, was created by Mission Mutual and is also licensed under CC BY-SA 4.0.

This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Tyndale Open Study Notes

EXO

Exodus 1:1

- *Israel* is the name God had given to Jacob, son of Isaac and grandson of Abraham ([Genesis 32:28](#)).
- Years earlier, Jacob and his family moved to Egypt to escape a severe drought (see [Genesis 46:1-7](#)). His son Joseph's wisdom and leadership guaranteed a steady grain supply (see [Genesis 41:25-49](#); [Genesis 42:1-2](#); [45:5-7](#)).

Exodus 1:1-22

The need for rescue was clearly related to the Israelites' condition. The Egyptians forced the people of Israel to work without mercy ([1:13](#)). It was also related to promises God had made to the patriarchs years earlier.

The Lord had promised Abraham that his descendants would become a great nation, living freely in the land of Canaan. At this time, Abraham's descendants were slaves in Egypt under a pharaoh who wanted to destroy them as a people. God would have to rescue them to fulfill his promises.

Exodus 1:2-4

To learn about the births of Jacob's sons, see [Genesis 29:31-30:24](#) and [35:16-18](#).

Exodus 1:5

- *seventy*: The number 75 in the ancient Greek version and the Dead Sea Scrolls might include the five sons of Ephraim and Manasseh ([Numbers 26:29, 35](#)).
- His jealous brothers sold Joseph, Jacob's eleventh son, into Egyptian slavery ([Genesis 37:18-28](#)). God did good for his people even though Joseph's brothers sinned. When Joseph was in Egypt, God used him to save the chosen people during a severe famine. Without Joseph, the famine could have destroyed them ([Genesis 42:1-2](#); [50:19-20](#)).

Exodus 1:6-7

Jacob's family stayed in Egypt for a long time as part of God's plan. God told Abraham that his descendants would not receive the land of Canaan for 400 years, until the Canaanites' sins were complete ([Genesis 15:13-16](#)).

Even in Egypt, God's promises were working. The descendants of the elderly Abraham and barren Sarah *multiplied ... exceedingly*, just as God had said ([Genesis 15:5](#)). This was because God blessed them ([Psalm 105:24](#)).

Exodus 1:8-10

From about 1650 to 1550 BC, Semitic invaders ruled northern Egypt, where the Israelites lived. The Egyptians called these rulers "shepherd kings" or *Hyksos*. Semitic peoples were ancient groups from the Middle East and North Africa, known for their shared languages (such as Hebrew, Aramaic, or Arabic) and cultural traditions.

Many scholars think these kings supported the Israelites, who might have allied with them. Egypt finally expelled the invaders around 1540 BC. The new rulers of Egypt's 18th Dynasty probably did not trust any remaining Semites, including the Israelites.

Exodus 1:10

The people Pharaoh called *our enemies* were probably the remaining Hyksos (see study note on 1:8–10).

Exodus 1:11

Archaeologists have identified *Pithom and Rameses* with the modern cities of Tell el-Maskhuta and Qantir. Ancient remains show people built these cities during the Late Bronze period (1550–1250 BC), when the Israelites were also present.

Exodus 1:12

Even though the Egyptians worked together to oppress them, the Israelites continued to multiply and spread throughout the land. In this way, God was keeping his promise to give Abraham many descendants ([Genesis 15:5](#)).

Exodus 1:14

The Egyptians could only get stone for building from the far south of the country. In the north, where the Hebrews lived, they used stone only for the most important state and religious buildings.

They built other structures with mortar and bricks made from durable clay. They mixed in seashells or straw to bind it together. After sun-drying in a mold, these materials were surprisingly strong. This was especially true in Egypt, where there was little rain or humidity.

Exodus 1:15

- *Pharaoh* is a title for the Egyptian ruler, not a personal name.
- The origin of the word Hebrew is not clear. When Egyptians and Philistines used this word for the Israelites, it may have been an insult. It likely described a low social class that other people considered unimportant or inferior.
- Whatever the number of Hebrew people, there were clearly more than two midwives for the whole nation (see study note on 12:37). Shiphrah and Puah probably represent the entire group.

The differences between Pharaoh and the midwives were very clear:

- Pharaoh had great political and military power, but the midwives had none.
- Pharaoh had high status, but they had little.
- Pharaoh was a man from the ruling people, and they were enslaved women.
- Pharaoh was rich, and they were poor.
- Pharaoh could have easily forced them to obey, but they did not give in.

Exodus 1:16

If the child is a son, kill him; but if it is a daughter, let her live: This command called for killing only the male children. It would not remove the Hebrews as a source of forced labor.

When the girls grew up, they could marry male slaves from other ethnic groups. In this way, the Hebrews would lose their unity as a people. At the same time, Egypt would still keep a large supply of slaves.

Exodus 1:17

The midwives, however, feared God and did not do as the king of Egypt had instructed: This was because they feared God more than they feared Pharaoh (1:21). *Fear of the Lord* refers to having reverent awe of him as the almighty Creator and Judge. This is the foundation of true knowledge and wisdom (Proverbs 1:7; 9:10).

The Lord is a friend to those who fear him (Psalm 25:14). The midwives understood that the Lord has more power than any human.

Exodus 1:19

Some people may feel concerned that the midwives did not speak openly about their main reason for keeping the baby boys alive.

However, this passage shows an important principle. Complete openness in every situation is not presented as more important than faithful loyalty to God and to his people. The midwives chose to protect life and to remain loyal to the Lord.

Exodus 1:20-21

He gave them families: For most of history, children have had the worthy goal of growing up to raise a family. God graciously granted the universal wish of these women who served him courageously and faithfully.

Exodus 2:1

- The man and woman were named *Amram* and *Jochebed* (6:20).
- Levi was Jacob's third son by his wife Leah (Genesis 29:34).

Exodus 2:1-25

[Chapter 1](#) explained why Israel needed rescue. [Chapter 2](#) shows how God prepared Moses, the rescuer. God used the threat to Hebrew baby boys to ensure that Moses was ready for his mission (see study note on 2:10).

Exodus 2:2

a special baby (literally *he was good*): This is probably a reference to his appearance: He was a "perfect" baby.

Exodus 2:3

Papyrus reeds grew plentifully along the many streams into which the Nile River divided in the delta region of northern Egypt. They were light and flexible, well-suited for basket weaving. It is possible that the mother of Moses placed the basket in the water exactly where it was most likely to be found by the Egyptian princess.

Exodus 2:5-6

The Egyptians believed that the Nile River was a goddess. They thought she gave life and healing. In this way, the Nile was similar to how some people in modern India view the Ganges River.

When Pharaoh's daughter went down to bathe in the river, she was doing more than washing herself. She was likely taking part in her morning religious practice.

When she found the baby floating on the river, she may have seen this as a sign from the Nile goddess. In her view, the child was in the care of the goddess. This would have made the discovery very important to her.

It is also natural for someone to feel compassion for a crying baby. These reasons together may explain why she rescued the child. She understood that he was a Hebrew boy. Hebrews and Egyptians practiced circumcision in different ways, which likely helped her recognize this.

These factors may explain why she rescued the child, even though she could tell he was Hebrew. Hebrews and Egyptians had different circumcision practices.

Exodus 2:7-9

This event shows God's grace (his undeserved kindness) and sovereignty (his complete rule and control). Pharaoh had ordered that Hebrew baby boys be killed. Yet Pharaoh's daughter paid the mother of Moses to nurse him instead.

The story may suggest that the princess understood who the baby's mother was. She did not ask questions that would have caused trouble. If this is correct, both women may have quietly understood the situation without speaking about it directly.

Moses was saved because God was working behind the events. He was not saved because someone was tricked or deceived.

Exodus 2:10

- God did more than save the life of Moses for his future calling. He also placed Moses in a position to receive training. Moses grew up in Pharaoh's household. There, he likely received an education in administration, military matters, and leadership. In Egypt, a pharaoh was expected to father many children. This showed his strength and power. His sons were often given important civil and military roles. An adopted son of a princess would likely have received this kind of training (see [Acts 7:22](#)).
- *Moses*: The princess gave the child an Egyptian name. This name appears in the longer names of many important Egyptians. These include the 18th Dynasty pharaohs Ahmose (1550–1525 BC) and Thutmose (1504–1390 BC).
The name *Moses* may mean “to give birth” in Egyptian. By using this name, the princess may have suggested that the Nile, which Egyptians honored as a source of life, had given birth to the child.
The Israelites later connected the name Moses with a similar Hebrew word, *mashah*. This word sounds like the name *Moses* and means “to lift out.” This connection recalls how the baby was lifted out of the water.

Exodus 2:11–12

Moses grew up with many advantages. He lived in comfort, unlike his own people, the Hebrews, who suffered hard labor and pain.

Even so, Moses chose to identify with them. He decided to stand with his people. He was willing to risk his position and comfort in order to help them.

Exodus 2:11–15

This section describes the first failed attempt of Moses to rescue Israel. He acted in his own strength instead of waiting for God's direction.

This event shows the courage and quick action of Moses. However, it also shows that he sometimes took responsibility on himself instead of trusting God's plan. Later in his life, this same pattern led to serious consequences ([Numbers 20:1–13](#)).

Moses cared deeply about his people's well-being. His desire to help was good. But the time and the way he acted did not match God's plan.

Exodus 2:13

Moses, who had put himself at risk to prevent an Egyptian from beating a Hebrew, must have been especially angered to see a Hebrew beating up a fellow Hebrew.

Exodus 2:14

“Who made you ruler and judge over us?”: The Hebrew man's arrogant question hints at how others would later treat *Moses*. They would not appreciate his efforts. For Moses to succeed, he would need to rely only on his belief in God's calling.

Exodus 2:15

- *Moses fled:* Moses tried to rescue Israel by himself instead of relying on God. This made him a fugitive in Egypt, delaying God's plans for him. His actions dramatically changed his life (compare [Numbers 20:9-13](#); [Deuteronomy 3:23-29](#)).
- Midian was on both sides of the Gulf of Aqaba, in the southern Sinai peninsula and the western edge of the Arabian peninsula. A major trade route from southern Arabia went through this dry and barren area. The people there were probably nomadic shepherds and traders (see [Genesis 37:28](#)). It was a good place for a fugitive to hide.

Exodus 2:16

the priest of Midian: His name was *Reuel* ([2:18](#)), but Scripture later calls him *Jethro* ([18:1](#)). It was common for a person to have both an official and a personal name. But it is unclear which one is in view here.

Perhaps, like Melchizedek, he was part of a local religious group that did not follow a pagan religion ([Genesis 14:18](#)). Reuel's actions in bringing an offering and sacrifices to God support this idea ([Exodus 18:12](#)).

Exodus 2:16-25

This passage shows the concern Moses felt for the oppressed. It describes his move to a new land ([2:18-22](#)). He married, had a child, and lived there for 40 years ([Acts 7:30](#)).

From a human perspective, rescuing the Israelites through Moses seemed impossible. But what God's perspective is what matters. The end of this section tells us that God had not forgotten his people ([Exodus 2:23-25](#)). He was only waiting for the right time to act ([2:25](#)).

Exodus 2:17

rose up to help: Moses, now in a foreign land, still could not ignore oppression. He was, by nature, a rescuer.

Exodus 2:18-20

The father of seven daughters did not want to miss meeting a generous and brave man, who would make an excellent husband. We see here the famous hospitality of the region's residents, which continues today (see also [Genesis 18:1-8](#)).

Exodus 2:24-25

The verbs here describe a God who understands his people's needs (*heard ... saw*) and who is faithful and reliable (*remembered His covenant*). He fulfills his responsibilities in a relationship (*took notice*).

Exodus 3:1

Sinai is the name commonly used for the mountain where God revealed himself in the covenant (see, for example, [16:1](#); [19:1-2](#)). Here and in [17:6](#) and [33:6](#), the Hebrew text uses the name *Horeb*. Both names probably refer to the same mountain.

Exodus 3:1-10

These verses indicate a major change will happen in the life of Moses.

Exodus 3:1-4:28

This section describes the mission God gave Moses to rescue the Israelites from Egyptian slavery. It is divided into two parts, [3:1-4:17](#) and [4:18-28](#).

The first part describes God's call. The second part describes the full consequences of accepting that call. Moses not only experienced a career change, but he also had to completely change his life.

Exodus 3:2

- *the angel of the LORD*: This is the Lord's official messenger. But the term can also refer to other visible signs of the Lord (see [Genesis 16:9–13](#); [Judges 13:3, 6, 21–22](#)).
- In the Bible, *blazing fire* often represents God's supreme holiness (see [Exodus 19:18](#); [Genesis 15:17](#); [1 Kgs 18:38–39](#); [Isaiah 33:14](#)).
- *was not consumed*: This may show that God does not want to destroy the object he sets on fire for his purposes.

Exodus 3:4

Moses, Moses!: God knows each person by name, and every individual matters to him.

Exodus 3:5

The soil around the bush was holy, while the soil on the sandals of Moses was common. The common cannot touch the holy without being transformed or destroyed (see “Clean, Unclean, and Holy” Theme Note). At the start of the exodus, God made it clear that he is completely different from his creation. This is important for a proper relationship between God and humans.

The word *holy* appears only a few times in the Bible before [Exodus 3:5](#). It then becomes the main way to describe God in the Old Testament. In other Semitic languages, the same root word is rare. Semitic people were ancient groups from the Middle East and North Africa, known for their shared languages (such as Hebrew, Aramaic, or Arabic) and cultural traditions.

Holy does not describe a moral quality in these languages but simply what is “other than” human. Pagan gods were “holy” only in the sense of being “other.” They did everything humans do, both good and evil, but on a larger scale.

In the Bible, holiness first means being set apart. God alone is completely distinct from creation and worthy of being called holy in the fullest sense. His holiness includes moral perfection. He is perfectly consistent and moral in his character. Here, at the burning bush, God revealed his otherness. Later at

Sinai, he revealed his moral character in his requirements for those who would be his covenant partners (see [Exodus 19:6](#); [20:1–23:33](#); see also [Leviticus 11:45](#); [1 Peter 1:13–16](#)).

Exodus 3:6

This transcendent God (the God who is above and beyond creation) had made a faithful promise to the ancestors of Moses. He had kept this promise for hundreds of years.

Moses stood in awe of the one holy and transcendent God of Abraham. This is the God who set himself apart from all other gods.

Later, Jesus quoted this verse when he spoke with the Sadducees about the resurrection ([Matthew 22:32](#); [Mark 12:26](#); [Luke 20:37](#)).

Exodus 3:7

God felt compassion for the ongoing slavery and suffering of Israel.

Exodus 3:8

- God would not only *rescue* them but also *bring them ... to a good ... land*, which he had promised to Abraham ([Genesis 13:14–18](#)).
- *flowing with milk and honey*: The land was rich for farming, with fields for cattle and crops with blossoms that allowed bees to make honey.
- *Canaanites ... Jebusites*: The list of peoples who lived in Canaan shows the importance of this land between the Mediterranean Sea and the Arabian Desert. It was a key crossroads for trade and communication between Egypt and the rest of the ancient Near East. It was a highly contested prize. It seemed impossible that Israel would end up as the only owner.

Exodus 3:10

God would act compassionately to save his suffering people, but it would be through a human agency. Often God is known among us because of the way his people carry out his will.

Exodus 3:11–12

Moses first protested that he was unworthy of such a great task, but God responded that this was not the issue. Human worthiness is of no significance if God's presence is with that person.

Exodus 3:11–4:17

Moses, in his response to God, presented four reasons why he was not the one to fulfill God's call. Although each reason supposedly relates to Moses and his ability, God's answers show that they were really questions about God.

Exodus 3:12

In the Bible, a sign often occurred after a person or a nation had already had to decide whether to act in faith or not (see [Isaiah 7:14](#)). A sign cannot create faith where there is none (see [Matthew 12:39](#); [16:4](#)). Rather, it encourages the one who has exercised the faith he or she already has.

Exodus 3:13–22

The second protest Moses made was about his lack of knowledge. He said that he did not know God's name.

This could mean that God's personal name had not yet been made known to him (see study notes on 6:2–3). It could also mean something else. In the ancient Near East, people often believed that knowing a god's secret name gave them power. Moses may have wondered if he needed such a secret formula (special words believed to control spiritual power).

God's answer is direct, but it sounds almost like a riddle at first. However, most of his answer does not focus on a secret name. Instead, God speaks about his faithfulness in the past and his plans for

the future. He shows that he knows what will happen and that he controls history.

There is nothing magical about the name "the LORD" (Hebrew *Yahweh*). The issue is not secret knowledge or magic power. The issue is who God is.

The name is important because of the character and nature of the one who bears it. God is faithful, powerful, and Lord over all of history.

Exodus 3:14

I AM WHO I AM: This name speaks of a God who is self-sufficient, self-existent, all encompassing, and without limitations, the one being in the universe who is not dependent on something else for his existence.

Exodus 3:15

The LORD: The Hebrew name probably comes from the Hebrew verb "to be," meaning "he causes to be," "he who is," or "I am." Later, Jews would not say God's name aloud. So, the Hebrew text uses the vowels from the word *'adonay* (meaning "lord" or "master") whenever God's name, *YHWH*, appears.

A Jewish person reading aloud would say *'adonay*, even though the text is written *YHWH*. We do not know the exact pronunciation of the divine name. The widely-used *Yahweh* is an educated guess.

The English word *Jehovah* is a made-up term, combining the vowels of *'adonay* with the consonants Y-H-W-H. The Berean Standard Bible usually translates the name as *LORD*. See [6:2–3](#); [15:3](#); [33:19](#); [34:5–6](#).

Exodus 3:16-17

- *God* ordered Moses to tell the people of Israel that the *God* speaking to them now was the same *God* their ancestors knew and worshiped. This *God* would lead them into a fruitful *land* captured from others. The message of Moses was not a magical formula. Instead, it was the word of God who, although outside of history, can still enter and direct it.
- *flowing with milk and honey*: See study note on 3:8.

Exodus 3:18

- *Hebrews*: See study note on 1:15.
- *a three-day journey ... so that we may sacrifice*: If we view the main goal of the exodus as rescuing the Israelites from slavery, this request might seem insincere. But God's main goal was to create a nation for himself. He led them into the wilderness to teach them how to worship him.

Exodus 3:19

I know: See "Hardened Hearts" Theme Note.

Exodus 3:20-21

God's power would be obvious, and the Egyptians would not only allow the Hebrews to leave, they would pay them to do so.

Exodus 4:1-9

The third protest of Moses was that he did not have enough power. He felt unable to do what God asked him to do.

God answered by showing his own great power. He performed signs immediately. He turned the staff of Moses into a snake. He also caused a serious skin disease to appear and then disappear at once.

Exodus 4:3

Across the ancient Near East, the snake was a symbol of both death and healing. The person who demonstrated power in these areas was powerful indeed.

Exodus 4:6

leprous: The Hebrew word for this phrase has traditionally been translated as *leprosy*. But the symptoms described in the Bible do not match leprosy (Hansen's disease). The biblical term probably refers to various highly contagious skin inflammations and lesions.

Exodus 4:9

As with the previous two signs, the fact that the water from the Nile will turn to blood also demonstrated God's power over life and death.

Exodus 4:10-17

The fourth and final protest of Moses was that he could not speak well. He seemed desperate to avoid this difficult task.

God was becoming angry at Moses for refusing to accept the truth. The outcome did not depend on the ability of Moses. Instead, it depended on his willingness to let God's power work through him.

Exodus 4:11

God created the organs of speech. These include the mouth, tongue, and lips. He has also decided each person's abilities in speaking.

God can use the abilities he has given. He is able to work through what he has created and chosen.

Exodus 4:13

After raising several objections, Moses had no more arguments. So he simply asked the Lord to excuse him from the task.

Exodus 4:14–17

God did not allow Moses to avoid his responsibility. However, he responded to the concern of Moses by appointing his brother Aaron to speak for him ([14:16](#)). Aaron would serve as the mouthpiece of Moses before Pharaoh and the people.

As the story continues, the text records fewer occasions when Aaron speaks on behalf of Moses. Moses increasingly speaks directly.

This suggests that the speaking difficulty of Moses may not have been as severe as he feared. It may also be that his confidence and ability grew with experience.

Exodus 4:18

Moses was now 80 years old (see [7:7](#)). Even so, he was still formally under the authority of his father-in-law.

Exodus 4:20

he took the staff of God: Whatever he may have said to Jethro, Moses was going to Egypt in obedience to God and in the expectation of being used by God (see [4:17](#)).

Exodus 4:21–23

These verses summarize the upcoming chapters. They start with the request to let the people go to worship God and end with the final plague, the death of the firstborn ([5:3](#); [11:4–6](#)). God was preparing the rescuer for the challenging task ahead (see [11:9](#)).

Exodus 4:24–26

This incident is mysterious. Zipporah immediately circumcising her son suggests she and Moses had previously discussed it and decided it was unnecessary. Why would having an uncircumcised son make God want to kill the rescuer he had prepared and called?

It would seem strange for Moses to arrive in Egypt claiming to represent the God of the Israelites'

ancestors, but would not do what God commanded them ([Genesis 17:10](#)). This might cause the people to be less willing to follow God exclusively.

Exodus 4:25

a bridegroom of blood: The context suggests that this statement was part of a circumcision ceremony.

Circumcision was the cutting of the foreskin of a male child. It may reflect an older custom among some Semitic peoples (ancient groups from the Middle East who spoke related languages).

Among some groups, including certain African communities today, circumcision is performed at puberty rather than in infancy. If that were the case here, the phrase may connect circumcision with marriage or adulthood.

Exodus 4:27

- Aaron's coming to meet Moses is the first recorded confirmation of God's promises (see [4:14](#)).
- *mountain of God:* This refers to Mount Sinai.

Exodus 4:29–7.7

In this section, the Lord promised to rescue the Israelites. He said that he would bring them out of slavery.

At first, the people responded in a positive way. They believed what God said. However, later they faced a crisis of faith. They began to doubt God's promise and struggled to trust him.

Exodus 4:31

they believed: The initial response to the good news was one of faith and worship. Contrast the response of panic in [14:10–12](#), when they saw Pharaoh chasing them.

Exodus 5:1

so that they may hold a feast: See study note on 3:18.

Exodus 5:1-14

Pharaoh not only rejected the request of Moses to release the Hebrew slaves, he also retaliated by making their work harder. The arrival of the rescuer had actually made the situation worse.

Exodus 5:2

Pharaoh quickly addressed the main issue. What god could be greater than Pharaoh? What god could make him do something against his will? This is a key question for all people. Is there anyone or anything more important than my own interests?

Exodus 5:3

He may strike us: God had not said this. Perhaps Moses and Aaron were trying to strengthen their case by saying that they had to obey God or die.

Exodus 5:4-5

It seems that the people expected the freedom God had promised. Because of this, they stopped their work.

Exodus 5:6-14

Pharaoh increased the workload to punish their disobedience. He thought they had too much free time (5:8). He could not imagine a god revealing himself outside the royal worship system. He believed they invented their unusual religious ideas instead of working (see also 5:17).

Exodus 5:7

Straw is a binder to help clay and mud bricks retain their form while drying in the sun.

Exodus 5:22

The phrase *brought trouble upon this people* could be translated more strongly as *caused evil for this people*.

Is God truly good? God did not rescue the people from their difficult situations as he promised. It seems he has made things worse. Is he faithful or not? Is he powerful or not? (compare [Psalm 105:25-27](#)).

Exodus 5:22-23

This moment was a turning point. After the first strong response of hope (4:29-31), the promise of rescue led to doubt and anger. The people faced even harsher oppression than before.

Moses, who was called to rescue them, also began to doubt. The situation tested his faith.

Exodus 6:1

Now you will see: This means that God was about to act. He was not discouraged by the questions about his faithfulness, his power, or his character.

Instead, God looked ahead to the coming conflict. Different worldviews (ways of understanding life and reality) would confront each other.

Pharaoh believed that he was divine. However, he would become only an instrument in the hand of the one true God.

Exodus 6:1-13

God renewed his promises. The offer of rescue emphasized the main question. Pharaoh asked: "Who is the LORD?" (5:2). While the Israelites needed rescue from slavery, their greater need was to know the Lord. The main purpose of God's renewed promises was "you will know that I am the LORD your God" (6:7).

Exodus 6:2-3

- *I am the LORD ... God Almighty:* Here, the Hebrew *El-Shaddai* is translated “God Almighty.” God was emphasizing that he was revealing himself in a new way. The patriarchs (Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob) knew him especially as *God Almighty*. Now he was making his name *Yahweh* (LORD) known more fully to Moses and the Israelites. The point is not that the name *Yahweh* was completely unknown before. Rather, God was now showing more clearly what that name means through his powerful acts of rescue.
- *by My name the LORD I did not make Myself known to them:* The name LORD (*Yahweh*) appears often in Genesis. There are two possible explanations:
 1. The patriarchs did not know the name *Yahweh*, but God inspired Moses, who wrote Genesis, to use it. This was wherever God's grace and covenant-keeping nature were evident.

2. While the patriarchs might have known the name *Yahweh*, they might not have seen God's nature as clearly as during the exodus and the Sinai covenant. In Hebrew, a person's name has more importance than in English. Names showed character and nature, and were not only labels (see, for example, [Psalms 8:1, 9; 148:13](#)). Here, *make known* implies intimate knowledge and experience. In this case, the patriarchs knew God's name, but they did not know and experience his nature fully as he revealed himself in the exodus.

Exodus 6:2-8

Once again, God clearly connected his present action with the promises he made to the patriarchs (Abraham and his family). God works in history in ways that show his faithfulness. He makes promises, and he keeps them.

God also planned to reveal more about himself than he had revealed to the patriarchs. This new generation would understand more about who he is and what he intends to do. They would especially learn more about the meaning and demands of the covenant ([6:4-5](#)).

Why does God redeem his people ([6:6](#))? Why did he first reveal himself to Abraham? Why did he first reveal himself to Abraham?

God wanted the Israelites to belong to him as his own people. He also wanted to be their God ([6:7](#)). This mutual relationship was always his goal.

God's purpose is for humankind to live in a loving and willing covenant relationship with him. In that relationship, people can become what he created them to be.

Exodus 6:7

Then you will know that I am the LORD: The Hebrew word translated *know* is always about experience and relationship. This word also describes human sexual relations. To *know* God as *the LORD* means more than just knowing facts about him. It means being in a relationship with him where we continually learn who he is and what he wants us to do.

This is the only true rescue from the human problem of sin described in [Genesis 3-11](#). The idea of *knowing the Lord* is very important in the book of Exodus. The phrase appears many times, especially in [Exodus 5-18](#) ([5:2](#); [7:5](#), [17](#); [8:10](#), [22](#); [9:29](#); [10:2](#); [11:7](#); [14:4](#), [18](#); [16:6](#), [12](#); [18:11](#)).

Exodus 6:9

The crisis became worse because the people ignored the repeated promises. They had not anticipated that their initial faith would produce greater problems for them.

Exodus 6:10-13

The crisis reached its lowest point. Even Moses returned to the same struggle he had faced at Mount Sinai. There, when God first called him, Moses had protested and said he was not able to do the task ([3:1-4:13](#)).

Now Moses once again felt unsure and overwhelmed. However, God did not change his plan. He renewed his command and sent Moses forward again.

Exodus 6:14-16

The list of ancestors moves step by step through Jacob's sons. It begins with the first son, then the second, and then the third, Levi. Levi was the ancestor of Moses and Aaron.

After reaching Levi, the list of ancestors does not continue with the other nine sons. Instead, it focuses on Levi's family line. This focus prepares the reader to understand the role of Moses and Aaron in God's plan.

Exodus 6:14-30

This section referring to family lineage places Moses and Aaron within the families of Israel. It is obviously background information because [6:30](#) repeats [6:12](#). Exodus often emphasizes the Lord as the God of the ancestors, both directly (from [3:6](#) onward) and indirectly (from [1:1](#) onward). The upcoming events were not actions by a new god dismissing older gods (a common theme in ancient pagan stories).

Unlike pagan gods, who only want personal power and often fight among themselves, the true God has one main goal. God wants his creation to find fulfillment in a proper relationship with him. Although God shows this purpose through creative acts, these actions always align with what he has already revealed about himself.

Moses and Aaron did not suddenly appear out of the unknown, but were an essential part of that same people to whom God first revealed himself and through whom he was about to give an even grander revelation. The family lineage of Jesus has a similar purpose ([Matthew 1:1-16](#); [Luke 3:23-38](#)).

Exodus 6:16-20

This list of Levi's descendants focuses on Aaron and Moses. It shows four generations from Levi to Aaron and Moses (compare [Genesis 15:16](#)). The Israelites lived in Egypt for 430 years (see [Exodus 12:40-41](#); [Genesis 15:13](#)). So, this list of ancestors does not include many generations.

[Genesis 46:11](#) lists Gershon, Kohath, and Merari. They are Levi's sons who moved to Egypt with their father and Jacob's family. Amram's wife, Jochebed, gave birth to his sons ([Exodus 6:20](#)).

The language is clear, so it is likely there are generations not listed between Amram and Aaron and Moses. This suggests the missing generations were between Kohath (Levi's son) and Amram (father of Aaron and Moses).

Exodus 6:18

The sons of Kohath were Amram, Izhar, Hebron, and Uzziel. The Hebrew word for "sons" can also mean "descendants." This meaning allows for the possibility that some generations are not listed by name.

Exodus 6:20–25

The list of ancestors now focuses on the descendants of Kohath. It gives more detail about two family lines:

- Aaron, the son of Amram, and
- Korah, the son of Izhar ([6:23–24](#)).

It then names one of Aaron's sons, Eleazar ([6:25](#)). The main focus is Aaron's line through Eleazar, who later received the high priesthood.

Aaron and Korah were cousins. This family connection helps explain why Aaron's appointment as high priest caused strong resentment in Korah (see [Numbers 16:1–3](#)). Conflict within families is not new.

Korah and his sons may be mentioned in detail here because of Korah's later rebellion. That event made his family line important in Israel's history.

Exodus 7:1–7

In this final scene before the rescue begins, the Lord again answered the fear that Moses had about not speaking well. God allowed Moses to speak through Aaron (see [4:16](#)). Even so, Pharaoh would still refuse to listen.

The outcome did not depend on the ability of Moses to speak. It depended on God's power.

Moses and Aaron obeyed God's command. They acted in faith and went forward as he directed.

The first crisis had now passed (see study note on [5:22–23](#)).

Exodus 7:3

The Lord would use miraculous signs and wonders to convince Pharaoh, just as he had promised to use signs to convince the Israelites that they should follow Moses ([3:12](#); [4:5](#), [8](#), [9](#)).

Exodus 7:5

My hand: God would show more of his strength during the Israelites' exodus from Egypt. These events revealed that God's power has no equal.

Exodus 7:7

Although 80 years might seem old to us, it was not especially old in Moses and Aaron's family line. Their ancestors often lived between 130 and 140 years (see [6:16](#), [18](#), [20](#)).

Exodus 7:8–11.10

Through the plagues, God showed that the Egyptians' gods were not true sources of life. People believed these gods gave life and protection, but they could not save anyone.

Instead of bringing life, they were linked with death when compared to the Lord. Only the Lord has the power to give life (see [12:12](#); [18:11](#)).

Exodus 7:8–12.30

This section divides the events of rescue into two parts:

- the plagues ([7:8–11:10](#)) and
- the Passover ([12:1–30](#)).

God demonstrated that he is the Lord of life and death and nothing has any power against him (see [Isaiah 43:13](#)). The God of the patriarchs is also the God of the universe.

Exodus 7:9

serpent: The Hebrew word *tannin* is different from the word translated "snake" in [4:3](#). *Tannin* often refers to a sea monster. The Bible often describes Egypt as a powerless sea monster ([Isaiah 30:7](#); [Ezekiel 29:3](#)). The image of a cobra's head was on the pharaoh's headdress.

Exodus 7:11

they also did the same things (see also [7:22](#); [8:7](#)): This could be an example of demonic power, but these men could have used tricks too.

When they failed to reproduce the plague of gnats, they said it was "the finger of God" ([8:19](#)). This showed their actions were not from divine power.

Although the Egyptian magicians are unnamed here, tradition calls them *Jannes* and *Jambres* (see [2 Timothy 3:8](#)).

Exodus 7:14

See Theme Note for "Hardened Hearts."

Exodus 7:14–25

The first plague was the plague on the Nile, when the whole river turned to blood ([7:20](#)). The Egyptians correctly understood that without the Nile there would be no life in Egypt. They worshiped the Nile as the Mother of Egypt, but God showed that life is his to give or withhold.

Exodus 7:22

The Egyptian priests did not do anything as great as Moses and Aaron had done, but Pharaoh did not want to believe, so it took only the smallest thing to justify his unbelief.

Exodus 8:1–15

The second plague was the plague of frogs ([8:2](#)). The Egyptians gave special honor to amphibians such as frogs. These animals can live both in water and on land. Because of this, Egyptians connected them with life and survival. Egyptians were very concerned about life after death.

Through this plague, God showed that frogs do not control life. They do not have special power over survival.

Some people suggest that this plague happened naturally after the Nile River became unfit for life. However, the size and intensity of the plague were far greater than what would normally happen in nature.

Exodus 8:7–8

The magicians were able to duplicate the plague in some sense, but Pharaoh did not ask them to rid the land of the frogs. Instead, he begged Moses to ask God to take them away. He already knew where the real power was.

Exodus 8:9

In this instance, the evidence of God's power was not in the event per se but in the timing. God could keep the frogs alive or he could end their lives. Pharaoh needed only to say when.

Exodus 8:10

you may know that there is no one like the LORD our God: Again, the story emphasizes that the Lord alone is God (see [7:17](#)). These events were not primarily about rescue, but about the nature of reality.

Who was rescuing these people? Was it one of the gods, or the one true God, the Lord?

Exodus 8:13

Moses requested: Moses predicted that the plague would stop the next day. God also predicted that Pharaoh would refuse to listen (see [8:15](#)).

These statements show an important truth. The ability to predict the future is central to God's lordship (his rule and authority). God does not guess about what will happen. He knows what will happen.

God sees the future clearly. He also directs events according to his will. Because he knows and controls the future, he is truly the Lord.

Exodus 8:16–19

The third plague was the plague of gnats. The word translated *gnats* is very general. Technical Old Testament dictionaries often translate it as *vermin*. The English term *bugs* would come close. The whole land was infested with insects of one sort or another.

Exodus 8:19

This is the finger of God: See study note on 7:11.

Exodus 8:20–32

The fourth plague was the plague of flies. The Egyptians worshiped insects such as flies that seemed to be able to turn death into life, as their young seemed to emerge from decaying matter. If the Egyptians thought that insects had the secret of life, God would let them have all the insects they wanted. Some say that this infestation was the natural result of all the dead frogs, but there were no flies in Goshen ([8:22](#)), the northeastern delta area where the Hebrews lived. God's miraculous power was clearly seen in his ability to infest one area while sparing another at will.

Exodus 8:25

Pharaoh tried to make a bargain with God. He wanted to partly obey while keeping control. James describes such people as "a double-minded man" ([James 1:8](#)). This kind of person cannot receive anything from the Lord.

Exodus 8:26–27

- Moses explained why Pharaoh's request could not work. He said it would offend the Egyptians. The Egyptians looked down on the Hebrews and other Semitic peoples. They considered them uncultured and unclean (see [Genesis 43:32](#)).
- The Hebrews were leaving Egypt in order to worship the Lord (see, for example, [Exodus 5:1](#); [7:16](#); [8:1](#), [20](#)). God's purpose in the exodus was not only freedom from slavery. He wanted to bring his people into a right relationship with him.

Exodus 8:29–30

I will pray: Moses was learning the role of intercessor that would be so much a part of his life in future years (see, for example, [32:11–13](#), [30–32](#); [Numbers 14:13–19](#)). It must have been increasingly tempting to let the Egyptians continue to experience the results of their king's stubbornness, but Moses was willing to plead with

God not to leave them in a permanent state of grief and distress.

Exodus 9:1–7

The fifth plague was against the livestock. As with the withholding of flies from the area where the Hebrews lived ([8:22–23](#)), the distinction between the livestock of the Israelites and that of the Egyptians ([9:4](#)) shows that a natural explanation of this event is insufficient, even if the previous plagues contributed.

The Egyptians, like many in the ancient Near East, worshiped the ram, the goat, and the bull as representing power and fertility. These animals had no power before the Lord, in whom true power resides.

Exodus 9:3

- *Your livestock* refers specifically to field animals. Other animals would get boils in the next plague.
- Not every single livestock animal died. Some remained to protect from the hail of the seventh plague ([9:6](#); [9:20](#)).

Exodus 9:5–6

Prediction again played an important role. God announced what would happen before it took place.

These events were not random. They were directed by God, who rules over all that happens.

Exodus 9:8–12

The sixth plague caused painful boils on people and animals. The magicians could not copy this sign and could not protect themselves. They were completely defeated.

Exodus 9:12

Plagues five and six seemed to end on their own because Pharaoh did not plead for them to stop.

Exodus 9:13–33

The seventh plague was a hailstorm ([9:18](#)). It rains in Egypt only a few days each year. Hail and thunderstorms are rare. This storm would have terrified them. This may explain the increased theological reflection associated with it. The plague destroyed the flax and barley crops ([9:31](#)).

Exodus 9:14–17

God explained the purpose of the plagues to Pharaoh. They were meant to show that no one is like God in the entire world ([9:14](#); see also [Isaiah 46:9](#); [Jeremiah 10:6–7](#)). God did not destroy Pharaoh and Egypt in one strike, even though he could have. Instead, he spared them ([Exodus 9:16](#)).

God gave them a chance to recognize his power. But Pharaoh refused to humble himself and continued to oppress the Lord's people ([9:17](#)).

Exodus 9:16

In [Romans 9:17](#), Paul quotes from the Greek version of this verse when he speaks about God's rule over all things.

Exodus 9:20–21

Some of Pharaoh's officials began to understand what was happening. They learned from what they had seen and took steps to protect themselves.

But others followed Pharaoh's example. They refused to submit. Pride often controls a person's thinking and overrules clear judgment.

Exodus 9:26

The hail was not a normal storm. It was unusual in how wide the storm spread and what it damaged.

It did not fall everywhere in the same way. It struck some places but not others (see study note on [9:1–7](#)).

Exodus 9:27

Pharaoh had to face a clear conclusion. The evidence was strong and could not be ignored.

When he continued in pride, it was not just a mistake. It was sin.

Exodus 9:29

There is no one like the Lord in all the earth, and all the earth belongs to God ([9:14](#)). This was the clear message of the plagues. The Egyptians saw this message, but they struggled to accept it.

Exodus 10:1–20

The eighth plague was the plague of locusts ([10:4](#)). Enough time had passed since the previous plague for the wheat and spelt to sprout (see [9:32](#)).

The Egyptian god Osiris was highly honored by the people in Egypt. Egyptians believed he went down into the underworld and brought plant life back in the spring. For them, he was connected with renewal and life after death.

This second and climactic attack on plant life showed that even Osiris had no power before the Lord. God alone controls life and death.

New plants that grow in the spring do not give eternal life. True life comes from the Lord, not from nature or from any false god.

Exodus 10:2

God sent the plagues so Israel would know that *I am the LORD* (similar to Egypt, see [9:14–16](#)). God wanted his people to understand who he is and to trust him.

Exodus 10:4

These locusts were a type of grasshopper that migrates. They swarmed from desert areas and

could destroy large land areas by eating all the plants.

Exodus 10:7-11

The officials did not have royal honor to protect. So they were willing to learn from what had happened and to let the men go.

Pharaoh resisted again. He wanted to protect his public honor. He said the men could go only if they left their families behind. In this way, he hoped they would be forced to return.

Moses had never said they would come back. They said they were going into the wilderness to worship God. But once slaves are free, they do not willingly return to those who oppressed them. Pharaoh understood this.

Exodus 10:13

an east wind: The locust swarms came from the Arabian Desert, across the Red Sea to the east.

Exodus 10:13-15

The locust plague was a miracle. It began when Moses raised his staff.

It also covered the whole land, from one end of the country to the other. The locusts were very many, and there had never been a plague like it before.

Exodus 10:17

forgive my sin: Pharaoh's understanding grew deeper. He admitted that his pride and his refusal to keep his word were sins. He understood that sin cannot be ignored. It must be forgiven.

However, even though Pharaoh understood this truth, he still refused to obey. His heart (inner attitude) did not change.

Exodus 10:21-29

The ninth plague was the plague of darkness ([10:21](#)). The chief god of Egypt through the centuries, who appeared under several different names, was the sun. At this time, he was known as

Amon-Re. He was supreme over all the other gods and was considered to be the ultimate source of life. The Lord showed that the sun's light is completely under his control. God could shut it off from Egypt proper, while leaving it to shine in Goshen in the northeast part of the country ([10:23](#); see study note on 9:1-7).

Exodus 10:24

your flocks and herds must stay behind: Pharaoh again tried to keep some of his honor and authority after his great failure.

Even after all that had happened, he did not want to give up control completely.

Exodus 10:25-26

Moses would not compromise. He knew the Israelites would not leave any possessions behind. Instead, the Egyptians would give them gifts so they would leave quickly ([3:21-22](#)). Moses also emphasized worshiping God. This repeated focus on leaving Egypt for worship shows the main reason for their exodus was so they could become God's people (see study note on 8:26-27).

Exodus 10:27-29

Pharaoh seemed to understand that he had reached a point of no return. The plagues had shown him the power of the Lord. The only proper response was to submit.

Instead, he chose another path. If he would not submit, then he would try to silence the messenger. So he decided to threaten Moses rather than obey God.

This pattern appears again later in Scripture. During the life and ministry of Jesus, some religious leaders refused to accept what his works clearly showed. Instead of believing, they chose to kill him (see [John 11:45-53](#)).

Exodus 11:1-9

The final plague was the death of the firstborn sons. The Egyptians worshiped life. They gave so much attention to preparations for life after death

because they wanted to ensure that it would be at least as good as their lives in Egypt. Death itself is in God's hand. There is no underworld god who can ultimately defeat the God of life. Both life and death belong to the Lord.

Exodus 11:3

Pharaoh refused to recognize the truth, but the Lord ensured that the rest of Egypt would recognize it.

Exodus 11:5

In many parts of the world, people look to their children for survival. In many cultures, the firstborn son carries on the family line. If people have children, they may feel secure. They may believe that, even after they die, they will continue through their children.

When the Egyptian firstborn sons died, God showed that people cannot guarantee their own survival. Life is a gift. That gift is in the hand of the one Lord, the "I Am."

Exodus 11:7

In the fourth, fifth, seventh, and ninth plagues, the Lord made a clear distinction between his people and the Egyptians ([8:23](#); [9:6](#), [26](#); [10:23](#)). These events clearly resulted from the express activity of God and were not random natural disasters.

Exodus 11:8

Pharaoh had lost control. Moses was no longer making a request. He was now able to set the terms for the Israelites' departure from the country.

Exodus 12:1-30

The Lord gave Moses instructions for the Passover meal and the Feast of Unleavened Bread ([12:14-20](#)). Moses and the people then celebrated the first Passover ([12:21-30](#)).

Exodus 12:2

This month was the month Abib ([13:4](#); [23:15](#); [34:18](#); [Deuteronomy 16:1](#); later called by the Babylonian name, Nisan, [Nehemiah 2:1](#); [Esther 3:7](#)). This time falls within the months of March and April.

Many cultures held festivals about this time of the year, celebrating the renewal of plant life. Israel's festival celebrated the historic event in which God defeated death and rescued his people from bondage in Egypt.

Exodus 12:5

unblemished: We must give God our best, just as he gave us his best: "Christ, a lamb without blemish or spot" ([1 Peter 1:19](#)).

Exodus 12:6

the whole assembly of the congregation: The entire community experiences both the benefits and responsibilities of a relationship with God together.

Exodus 12:7

blood: God could not simply spare his people from this plague as he had with the others. Death rules in the world because of sin. In light of God's justice, sin cannot be ignored. He must punish or atone for it.

Blood represents life ([Leviticus 17:11](#)). So, it is the only acceptable way to forgive sins ([Hebrews 9:22](#)). As [Deuteronomy 6:9](#) suggests, doorframes represent the entirety of life as the place of entering and exiting.

Exodus 12:10

Since this was not a regular meal, none of the meat was to be saved for another day.

Exodus 12:11

be fully dressed: The Israelites needed to be ready to leave quickly.

Exodus 12:12

The plagues were primarily the Lord's judgment against all the gods of Egypt (see also [Numbers 33:4](#)).

Exodus 12:14

The Jewish people still celebrate Passover because it was a *permanent statute* for all generations.

Exodus 12:15

- *unleavened*: The Israelites needed unleavened bread (which was made without yeast) when they left Egypt in a hurry (see [12:34](#), [39](#)). The Feast of Unleavened Bread remembers that event.
Later in the Bible, yeast became a symbol of sin. Yeast spreads through dough, and in the same way sin spreads through people and communities. Jesus warned his disciples, "Beware of the leaven of the Pharisees" ([Matthew 16:6](#)). He was speaking about their teaching and hypocrisy.
- *cut off from Israel*: This phrase means that a person would either be put to death or removed from the community. Being removed meant losing protection, family support, and the right to worship with God's people.

Exodus 12:22

Hyssop is a small bush with firm, compact branches that a person can use as a brush (see also [Psalm 51:7](#) and study note).

Exodus 12:25

the land that the LORD will give you: This refers to the land of Canaan. God had earlier promised this land to Abraham ([Genesis 12:7](#); [13:14–17](#)).

Exodus 12:26–27

In the future, the *Passover* celebration would be a memorial reminding future generations of Israelites of God's grace in providing them a way of escape from death. For more than 3,000 years the Jewish people have celebrated this important event in their history.

Exodus 12:28–30

The predicted plague was fulfilled. Just as death spares no one, so no one in Egypt, from Pharaoh to the lowest prisoner, escaped the effects of Pharaoh's pride.

Exodus 12:31–33

The same Pharaoh who had said that Moses would never again see his face and live (see [10:28](#)) now asked for Moses to come and see him. Just as God had predicted, Pharaoh then ordered the Israelites to leave his land. He implicitly recognized the Lord's power as he asked Moses to bless him. He never formally admitted that the Lord is God and that he, Pharaoh, was not.

Exodus 12:31–14:31

The Lord delivered on his promises and rescued Israel, bringing them out of Egypt.

Exodus 12:35

asked the Egyptians: See [3:22](#); [11:2](#).

Exodus 12:37

Scholars often identify *Succoth* with Tell el-Maskhuta. The mention of 600,000 men in [Numbers 1:46](#) suggests about 2.5 million people in total.

If this large number is literal, it presents some challenges:

1. The camp area would cover 643 square kilometers (400 square miles).
2. A column of people 1,000 wide would stretch nearly a mile and take 20 hours to pass one point.
3. No other known armies in the ancient Near East were this large.

Scholars suggest two possible explanations:

1. The number might be symbolic, showing that God greatly blessed Israel. Although unusual to us, this was acceptable in the ancient world.
2. The Hebrew word for “thousand” (*‘elep*) might actually be “troop” (*‘allup*). If so, it originally meant “600 troops of fighting men.” With each troop having about 100 men, the total population would be much smaller.

Despite the logistical issues, it is possible there were indeed 2.5 million Israelites.

Exodus 12:38

a mixed multitude: Some of these people later became unhappy and caused the Israelites to complain about their problems (see [Numbers 11:4](#)). We are not told why they joined the Israelites. Perhaps some trusted in the Lord because of the plagues. Others probably saw it as a chance for a better life elsewhere.

Exodus 12:40

According to the Septuagint and the Samaritan Pentateuch, the 430 years span from the promise to Abraham until the exodus from Egypt ([Genesis 12: 15](#)). Compare [Galatians 3:17](#); see also Exodus Book Introduction, The Date of the Exodus.

Exodus 12:43–50

These extra instructions for celebrating Passover mainly refer to outsiders and foreigners ([12:43](#); [12:48](#)). The presence of non-Israelite groups in the

community might have led to these rules ([12:38](#)). The main point was whether the person was willing to fully join Israel and obey the Lord by being circumcised.

Exodus 12:46

you may not break any of the bones: The apostle John refers to this rule about Passover lambs when he reports that they did not break the legs of Jesus when he was on the cross ([John 19:36](#)).

Exodus 12:51

The Israelites left Egypt in an orderly way, like a large army. The Lord led them as their commander and leader.

Exodus 13:1–10

This review of the customs for Passover and the Feast of Unleavened Bread prepares the way for teaching about the dedication of the firstborn ([13:11–16](#)).

Exodus 13:1–16

Like the Passover celebration, the dedication of the firstborn helped the people remember what God did during the Passover. God spared the firstborn sons of Israel. Because of this, those firstborn sons belonged to him and had to be redeemed (bought back with a price).

Each year, the people sacrificed and ate a lamb. This act pointed forward to what God would do by giving his Son, Jesus Christ, as a substitute. All people deserve death because of sin. But God redeems them through a price, the life of his Son.

Exodus 13:5

a land flowing with milk and honey: This describes a land that is rich and good for farming. There is grass for cattle to eat, and there are many plants and flowers. From these flowers, bees can make honey.

Exodus 13:9

- The annual Passover celebration was a sign to show you belonged to the Lord. It marked his ownership, reinforcing a spiritual truth.
- *a sign ... and a reminder ... the Law of the LORD*: The second part of the verse can be seen either as a statement to recite or as a description of the God's work.

Exodus 13:13

Parents had to redeem their firstborn son. They could not sacrifice him to the Lord, as child sacrifice is condemned throughout Scripture (see [Leviticus 18:21](#); [20:2](#); [Ezekiel 23:37–39](#)).

Exodus 13:16

Like the yearly Passover celebration, dedicating the firstborn to the Lord was a visible sign of belonging to the LORD ([13:9](#)).

Exodus 13:17–18

If the people face war: The Israelites had not yet seen God fight on their behalf. Even though they left Egypt like an army ready for battle ([13:18](#); see also [12:51](#)), it was only an appearance. Until they experienced the Lord as fighting for them ([14:14](#)) in the crossing of the sea, they were not ready to face enemies in the promised land.

Exodus 13:17–14:4

The Lord's redemptive power was demonstrated as he brought Israel into a place where they were completely helpless and had to either rely on him for rescue or die.

At the time, it might have seemed foolish. But Israel would thank God throughout its history for guiding them to that situation (see [Psalm 106:7–12](#); compare [Isaiah 12:2–6](#)).

Exodus 13:18

- *around by the way*: There is disagreement among scholars about the identification of some of the sites mentioned ([13:20](#); [14:2](#)). So, there is little agreement on the exact route the Israelites took.
- *Red Sea* (literally *sea of reeds*): The actual Red Sea is too far south. The Sea of Reeds was part of the Red Sea, probably located at the northern end of the Gulf of Suez.

Exodus 13:19

Joseph knew that God would not leave his people in Egypt forever. God had promised them the land of Canaan (see [Genesis 50:24–25](#)).

Exodus 13:20

The locations of Succoth and Etham are uncertain, although the reference to the edge of the wilderness suggests that they were in the region southeast of the Nile delta toward the Gulf of Suez.

Exodus 13:21

The pillar of cloud and pillar of fire stayed with the Israelites for the next 40 years.

Exodus 14:2

- The exact locations of Pi-hahiroth, Migdol, and Baal-zephon are unknown.
- *the sea*: See study note on 13:18.

Exodus 14:4

- *know that I am the LORD:* This event was the climactic (final and most important) demonstration of the Lord's character and power in the Exodus. Through it, God showed clearly who he is and what he can do. Rescue comes through God's self-revelation. This means that God saves people by making himself known. God does this by entering into human life and experience. He makes himself present and active among his people.
- *this is what the Israelites did:* In this part of the book, the Israelites were obedient to God's commands ([12:35](#), [50](#)). Unfortunately, they did not continue this pattern after crossing the Red Sea.

Exodus 14:5–14

Pharaoh and his officials did not truly repent. Once the immediate fear faded, they focused on their own interests and they determined to recapture their slave labor.

Exodus 14:6–7

chariot: At this time in history, the Egyptian light chariot was the top weapon. Pulled by three horses, it was fast and easy to maneuver. Sometimes one person operated it, but some ancient pictures show a driver with a warrior. The mention of officers may suggest these two-man teams. The world's strongest military power was gathering against the Hebrews.

Exodus 14:9

Today, we do not know the exact place where these events happened (see study note on 14:2). However, the original narrator and the first people to hear this story did know the location.

We should not assume that the account is fictional just because we lack precise geographic details

today. The story is presented as a real event that took place in a known setting.

Exodus 14:10–12

This complaint is the first of many that would follow during the next 40 years. Instead of trusting the God who had shown his great power, the Israelites turned against the one who had rescued them.

Their response shows a deeper problem. An unsundered heart (a person's inner attitude, will, or decision-making center) prefers safety over trust.

In simple terms, their attitude was this: "It is better to return to the security of slavery than to face the risk of trusting God."

Exodus 14:13–14

At least one person learned from the plagues and applied it to this crisis of faith. Moses did not know what God would do, but he made one of the great statements of faith in the Bible. Moses expressed his confidence in God. It was not the Lord who would fail, but the Egyptians.

Exodus 14:15–31

The escape through the Red Sea was the climactic moment of rescue. It was the highest point of God's saving work in the exodus from Egypt.

Exodus 14:17

My great glory: The Hebrew word translated "glory" (*kabod*) connotes weightiness, significance, and reality. God demonstrated his authenticity while showing that all the political, military, and material glory of one of the greatest human cultures was only the thinnest of veils.

Exodus 14:19–25

Whereas the Hebrews had been in a panic the night before, now the highly disciplined Egyptian army was thrown into disarray. They knew they were

dealing with something far beyond their ability to comprehend or control.

Exodus 14:22

As with the plagues, naturalistic explanations for this event are beside the point. A strong, steady wind blowing across a relatively shallow, contained body of water can change its depth dramatically, but that does not produce dry ground, with walls of water on each side. The Lord can intervene in nature and do with it as he wishes.

Exodus 14:25

He twisted their chariot wheels: The ancient versions differ on the translation of this phrase. Perhaps there was deep sand where the water had been, and this broke the light wheels of the chariots. At any rate, the Egyptian charge through the sea failed, and they became terrified. • The Lord is fighting for them: Certainly by this time everyone in Egypt was aware of the special relationship between the Lord and his people.

Exodus 14:31

Finally, the people of Israel were moved to put their faith in the Lord: Sadly, it was very short-lived (see [15:24](#); [16:3](#)). • To be the Lord's servant is a position of high honor (see [Isa 42:1-4](#); [Matt 12:18](#)).

Exodus 15:1

Moses and the people: In this triumphant moment there was no division between them; they sang as one. • I will sing: The highly personal declarations of the first two verses emphasize the personal nature of God's relation to humans. He is not an impersonal force, but relates to us as one person relates to another. The songs of thanks and hymns of praise in the Bible characteristically give the reason for the thanks or praise early in the piece (see [Ps 95:1-3](#); [96:1-4](#)). The reason for the song is that the Lord . . . has triumphed gloriously. The community's faith in God through the dark night had been dramatically vindicated.

Exodus 15:1-5

God's salvation (deliverance) and rescue had meaning for personal faith.

Exodus 15:1-18

Scholars believe this song of rescue to be one of the oldest preserved examples of the Hebrew language, attesting to its importance in Israel's thought and faith. It is divided into three stanzas: [15:1-5](#), [6-12](#), [13-18](#). The first stanza rejoices in the Lord's personal rescue of Moses and his people (note the recurrence of the first-person pronouns). The second exults in the great contrast between the Lord and the Egyptians. The third stanza reflects on what these events would mean for the future.

Exodus 15:2

This statement is quoted in two other places, [Ps 118:14](#) and [Isa 12:2](#), which shows its importance. The "God of your father" ([Exod 3:6](#)) had become my God. The Israelites now knew God for themselves and not just as a historical memory.

Exodus 15:3

The Lord is a warrior: He will aggressively defend his own. He is not an oppressor, nor does he fight for the love of violence. But when his people are helpless before the enemy, whether external or internal, they can know that Yahweh, "He Who Is," is their defender ([Isa 59:15-19](#); [63:1-6](#); [Rev 11:17-18](#)). Regarding the name *Yahweh*, see study note on [Exod 3:15](#).

Exodus 15:6

Your right hand: This was usually the arm a warrior used to hold a sword.

Exodus 15:6-12

The personal tone continues as the Lord is referred to as you and is contrasted dramatically with them ([15:7](#)). All that the enemy intended ([15:9](#)) was brought to nothing ([15:10](#)) before the mighty power of God.

Exodus 15:8

blast (literally *nostrils*): In other contexts, the same word may be translated “anger.” The hot breath from God’s nose is an image of God’s anger. • your breath: The Hebrew word translated as “breath” (*ruakh*) is the same one translated as “wind” in [14:21](#) and as “Spirit” in [Gen 1:2](#). Nature is not God, but God is everywhere at work in nature.

Exodus 15:9–10

Compared to the Creator’s plans, all the plans of even the most powerful humans are nothing (see [Ps 2:2–5](#)). They are like dust that can be blown away with one puff of his breath (see [Isa 40:15–17](#)).

Exodus 15:11

The gods of the pagan nations are not in the same category as the Lord. They do not deserve to be called holy (see study note on 3:5).

Exodus 15:13

In light of God’s unfailing love and his might, there is no reason to doubt that he will be able to keep his promises. “Unfailing love” is a translation of the Hebrew word *khesed*, which speaks of the undeserved kindness and loyalty of a superior to an inferior. It is the most frequent descriptor of God’s character in the Old Testament (see [Ps 136](#)). If God had such a character but did not have the might to carry out his good intentions toward his people, his character would be of little value to us. The good news is that he has both a loving character and all power. • sacred home: God has chosen his people and gathered them to himself in order to dwell in their midst (see also [Exod 15:17](#)).

Exodus 15:13–18

The people God has redeemed have confidence for the future. In light of what the Lord had done in rescuing Israel from his enemies, there was no question that he would be able to carry through on his promise to take them safely into the Promised Land.

Exodus 15:14–15

Philistia, Edom, Moab, and Canaan are the four peoples that would most feel the hand of God’s judgment as he dispossessed them to give the land to the people of Israel. What God had done to Egypt would have been common news throughout that part of the world (see Rahab’s report in [Josh 2:9–11](#), where the same imagery as in [Exod 15:15](#), to melt away, is used).

Exodus 15:17

on the mountain of Your inheritance: In the ancient world, people believed that their gods lived on mountains.

In this way of speaking, the land of Canaan is pictured as the place where God lives and rules.

Exodus 15:19–21

In many ancient societies, men and women took part in ceremonies separately. Women often had special roles in songs of praise and in songs of mourning.

Exodus 15:22–27

- First at Marah and then at Elim, God gave water to the people.
- The exact location of the Desert of Shur is unknown ([15:22](#)).

Exodus 15:22–18:27

On the journey from the sea to Mount Sinai, God continued to care for the people’s needs. During the events where he rescued them, he showed his power. Here, he showed that he cares about their basic needs.

Exodus 15:23

The water likely had a high level of natural minerals, which made it taste bitter. This is common in the Sinai Desert.

Exodus 15:24

Instead of thinking about recent lessons in faith, the people lost hope and started to complain, as is often the case in difficult times. If complaining becomes a habit, it can lead to failure in the ultimate test, as it did for the Israelites (see [Numbers 14](#); [Psalm 95:7–11](#); [Hebrews 3:7–11](#)).

Exodus 15:25

See [2 Kings 2:19–22](#) for a similar event.

Exodus 15:26

The link between obeying God's commands and health is not random. God made the human body and cares about how his people live. In this covenant promise, God told Israel that obedience would bring protection from the diseases that affected Egypt.

This statement was made when the people needed water. It may suggest that the Egyptians had been drinking polluted water, which could make people sick.

Exodus 16:1–36

God demonstrated care for his people by providing manna and quail as food for them.

Exodus 16:2

grumbled: The people often showed their lack of faith by complaining.

Exodus 16:3

ate our fill of bread: The Israelites had been oppressed slaves in Egypt. Their complaint did not match the reality of their suffering.

One danger of complaining is that it can blind people to the truth. It can make the past seem better than it really was.

Faith responds differently. Faith is thankful for what God has already done and trusts him for what he will do in the future.

Exodus 16:4–5

These are the Lord's instructions for gathering the food that he would provide in the wilderness. Enough was provided for each day, with a double amount provided on the sixth day so that the people would not have to gather any on the Sabbath (see [16:21–30](#)). The Israelites thus observed the Sabbath even before it was codified in the Decalogue. We instinctively resist a style of life in which it is necessary to depend on God each day to supply our needs. We wish to have supplies in advance so that we can feel independent. God was training the people for a life of faith (cp. [Matt 6:11](#)).

Exodus 16:7

The Hebrew word translated glory connotes weightiness, substance, and reality. It is not the flimsy, ephemeral quality we often associate with the English term *glory*. It is more the idea of royal grandeur.

Exodus 16:15

The Hebrew man hu' (What is it?) came to be the name of the miraculous food ("manna," see [16:31](#)). For forty years, the people ate *what is it?* Jesus referred to himself as the fulfillment of the meaning of this miracle. He was the "true bread from heaven" that gives life ([John 6:32–35](#), [48](#), [51](#), [63](#)).

Exodus 16:19–20

For these instructions, see study note on 16:4–5.

Exodus 16:21–30

Although the Sabbath was a day set apart for the Lord ([16:23](#)), it was also the Lord's gift to his people ([16:29](#)). Rest and worship are not meant to

be an obligation, but a privilege. However, given the human determination to meet our needs in our own way, rest and worship are given as commands ([16:28](#)).

Exodus 16:32-36

The container of manna was to be preserved as a reminder of God's providential care for his people. He is powerful and deeply caring. Not only can he supply our needs, he wants to do so.

Exodus 16:35

until they arrived at the land: God's care for us is normally demonstrated in ordinary ways, as it would usually be for Israel after they arrived in Canaan (see [Josh 5:10-12](#)). That care is just as real as when it comes in extraordinary ways, as it did while Israel was in the wilderness.

Exodus 17:1

from place to place: With a large and diverse group, travel was undoubtedly slow and arduous. It is also possible that God was using this time to demonstrate his care by miraculously providing for their needs before bringing them to Mount Sinai and offering his covenant to them.

Exodus 17:2

testing the Lord is explained in [17:7](#). They doubted that God was really with them or cared for them, and they demanded that he prove his presence and care. God invites a test based on faith ("I do believe, but help me overcome my unbelief," [Mark 9:24](#)), but he abhors a test based on doubt (i.e., *I don't believe, and I think God should prove himself to me*, as in [John 6:30](#)). The test based on doubt makes us the judge and God the defendant.

Exodus 17:3

For a similar complaint, see study note on 16:3.

Exodus 17:6

- *Mount Sinai*: See study note on 3:1.
- *water will come out of it*: Note the similar way God provided for the people in [Numbers 20:11](#) (see also [Psalms 78:15-16](#); [105:41](#); [114:8](#); [Isaiah 48:21](#)).

Exodus 17:8

Amalek was the grandson of Esau ([Genesis 36:11-12](#)). Amalek's descendants were a nomadic people. This means they moved from place to place instead of living in one city.

They were loosely based in the land of Edom. This means Edom was their main area, even though they traveled often. They likely supported themselves by attacking and robbing nearby settled communities.

Exodus 17:8-16

Israel defeated the Amalekites only because God blessed them and took care of them.

Exodus 17:9

Joshua was Moses' trusted assistant ([33:11](#)) who would eventually become his successor ([Deut 31:7-8](#)). This early experience was important training for leading the people later in the conquest of the land. The Hebrew name *Joshua*, which means "savior," is equivalent to the Greek name *Jesus* (see also study note on Heb 4:8).

Exodus 17:9-13

This victory was a gift from God, as the description here makes clear. The determining factor was God's blessing, as indicated by Moses' upraised hands. This principle was illustrated again and again in the conquest of the land of Canaan. Without God's blessing, Israel could do nothing (see [Num 14:42-45](#); [Josh 7:10-12](#)).

Exodus 17:14-16

By their unprovoked attack on the people through whom God was extending his blessing, the Amalekites incurred the unending wrath of God. God's hand can be extended in blessing, or it can be extended in curse. Those who reject the hand of blessing experience the curse (see [1 Sam 15](#)).

Exodus 17:15

This banner was a battle flag. In [Isa 5:26](#), God lifted up a banner to call the nations to war against Israel. In [Isa 11:10, 12](#), the Messiah would be the banner calling the nations to bring his people home.

Exodus 17:16

They have raised their fist against the Lord's throne, so now: The NLT sees the fist raised against the Lord's throne as Amalek's aggression against the Lord and his people. The alternate interpretation sees a reference to Moses' own hands that were lifted to the Lord in prayer ([17:15](#)).

Exodus 18:1-12

Moses had apparently sent his wife and children back from Egypt at some point to stay with his father-in-law. In the intense confrontation with Pharaoh, Moses might have been afraid for their lives. Jethro now came to meet Moses and the Israelites, bringing Moses' family with him ([18:2-6](#)). In the context of the visit, Moses gave him a report, and Jethro was brought to faith through the testimony of the Lord's work.

Exodus 18:7

bowed low and kissed him: They asked about each other's well-being. These were typical greetings in that society.

Exodus 18:13-16

Moses had begun to take a role similar to Pharaoh's. He was making himself necessary for every decision the people faced.

Exodus 18:13-27

Jethro's wise advice shows another example of God's care and guidance. This time, God did not act through a miracle. Instead, He used practical wisdom.

Jethro taught Moses a new way to lead. He told Moses to share his authority with other capable leaders. This way of leadership is called delegation. It means giving responsibility to others.

Before this, Moses seems to have followed an Egyptian style of leadership. That system was very strict and top-down. All authority came from the pharaoh, who made decisions by his own command. No Egyptian law code from that time has been found.

Jethro suggested a different structure. By appointing leaders over groups of people, the work of Moses would become easier and more orderly.

Exodus 18:17-18

This kind of approach focuses too much on one leader. That is not good for the leader or for the people (see also [18:23](#)).

Exodus 18:19-22

Moses needed to distinguish between his teaching function, in which he received and declared God's decrees and instructions ([18:19-20](#)), and his administrative function, in which he applied all of those decrees and instructions ([18:21-22](#)).

Exodus 19:1

on the same day of the month that the Israelites had left the land of Egypt: It was now the fifteenth day of the third month.

Exodus 19:1-9

God prepared his people to receive the covenant by first reminding them of the past and of what they had learned about him ([19:4](#)). He then made promises about the future, which depended on their obedience ([19:5-6](#)). The final result was their

promise to obey what the Lord has commanded ([19:8](#)).

Exodus 19:2

The arrival at Sinai was a fulfillment of the promise made earlier to Moses at this same place ([3:12](#)).

Exodus 19:3

The house of Jacob ... the sons of Israel: The connection between Jacob and the present generation showed that God's work continued from the past to the present. The same family line was still part of God's plan.

God had kept all his promises up to that time. The promises he would make in the future would also be trustworthy.

Exodus 19:5–6

- God, who owns all the earth, promised to make Israel his *treasured possession*. This promise depended on their acceptance and faithful keeping of a covenant with God.
- *unto Me you shall be a kingdom of priests and a holy nation:* The nation was to act as intercessors between a holy God and a lost world. God would reveal himself through Israel (see [1 Peter 2:9–10](#)).

Exodus 19:7–8

The first phase of preparation was successful. The people agreed to do everything the Lord has commanded.

Exodus 19:9

See also [Deuteronomy 4:12](#) and [33](#).

Exodus 19:10–15

- In the second stage of preparation, the people received commands that helped them get ready for God's covenant.

First, they had to wash their clothing ([19:10](#), [14](#)). This act showed that God is pure.

Second, they had to set up a boundary around the mountain and not cross it ([19:12–13](#)). This command showed that God is holy (completely set apart).

Third, they had to abstain from sexual relations ([19:15](#)). This instruction reminded them that God is not a sexual being and that his blessings do not come from sexual activity.

These actions were not sinful in themselves. Under normal conditions, they were good and natural. However, the people had to set them aside for a special purpose.

They needed to focus completely on the Lord, their King, who was about to appear before them.

Only their obedience to the boundary command is clearly reported ([19:23](#)). Even so, since no judgment from the Lord is recorded, it is reasonable to conclude that they obeyed the other commands as well.

- [Hebrews 12:18–22](#) compares this event at Mount Sinai with the believer's experience at Mount Zion, which it calls "the heavenly Jerusalem."

Exodus 19:16–25

The final phase of preparation involved phenomena that moved the people toward acceptance of the covenant. Some of the experiences were visual: lightning and a cloud ([19:16](#)), smoke and fire ([19:18](#)). The people also heard thunder, a ram's horn, and the voice of God ([19:16](#), [19](#)), and the whole mountain shook violently ([19:18](#)). In the Bible, such phenomena are

often associated with a *theophany*, which is a visible manifestation of God's holy presence.

Exodus 19:21-25

The repeated warnings that no one should break through to approach the Lord reinforced the impact of the phenomena the people had just witnessed. God is utterly transcendent, and he must be approached in the way he ordains or not at all.

Exodus 20:1

This corresponds to the introductory statement in the ancient covenant format. • all these instructions (literally *all these words*): When these statements are referred to elsewhere ([34:28](#); [Deut 4:13](#); [10:4](#)), the Hebrew text refers to them as the "Ten Words." These are not arbitrary commandments, but an explanation of God's basic instructions for human living given by the Creator of human life.

Exodus 20:1-17

This is a short summary of the terms of the covenant (see also [Deuteronomy 5:6-21](#)).

Exodus 20:1-23:33

The Sinai covenant follows closely the pattern of treaties made in the ancient Near East. In those treaties, a great king made an agreement with smaller nations. The great king was called a *suzerain* (a powerful ruler). The smaller nations were called *vassals* (people or nations under his rule).

These treaties usually followed a clear structure:

1. The treaty began with an introduction. This section named the great king who was offering the covenant ([20:1](#)).

2. Next came a historical preamble (an introduction that explains past events). This section described what had already happened between the king and the people ([20:2](#)). In Exodus, God reminds Israel that he brought them out of slavery in Egypt. This shows why he has the right to make a covenant with them.
3. Then the treaty listed the stipulations (the required terms of the agreement). These explained what each side promised to do. In ancient treaties, the king promised protection from enemies and help in times of danger. The people promised loyalty and obedience. In Exodus, the basic terms of the covenant appear in [20:3-17](#). These verses include the Ten Commandments. The laws are explained further in chapters [21-23](#).
4. The treaty also explained where the written copy should be kept and when it should be read publicly ([24:7](#); [25:16](#)). This ensured that future generations would remember the covenant.
5. Ancient treaties called on the gods to witness the agreement. In Exodus, instead of calling on pagan gods, historical events and written records serve as witnesses ([24:4](#)). This shows that Israel's covenant was different from pagan treaties.
6. Finally, treaties listed blessings and curses. Blessings would follow obedience. Curses would follow disobedience ([23:20-33](#)). This made it clear that the covenant had real consequences.

God used the familiar political treaty form of the ancient world. However, he removed pagan religious elements that were common at that time.

Through this covenant, God invited Israel into a formal relationship with himself as their king.

The Sermon on the Mount in the New Testament parallels this section of Exodus ([Matthew 5:1-7:29](#)). The Beatitudes ([Matthew 5:3-12](#)) correspond in some ways to the Ten Commandments.

Both passages describe how God's people should live under his rule.

Exodus 20:2

This sentence is part of the introduction in the ancient covenant format. It provides the historical context that makes the agreement between two groups possible and reasonable.

We are told that the *LORD your God* offered the covenant. He was not an unknown god who offered this special relationship. He was the God of Israel's ancestors who showed his power and care directly to them. This revelation was a gracious act of rescue, proving he is the only God.

Exodus 20:3

Not recognizing any other god is the first step toward learning the truth that there are no other gods besides the Lord (see [Deuteronomy 4:35](#); [6:4](#); [Isaiah 43:10-11](#); [45:21-22](#)).

Exodus 20:3-11

The first four commandments focus on a person's relationship with God. These commandments teach people how to honor and worship him in the right way.

If the Israelites obeyed these commandments, they would understand who God truly is. This would help them reject false ideas about God.

In Egypt, they had seen people worship many idols (images used as gods). Later, in Canaan, they would see similar idol worship again. The first four commandments helped them stay faithful to the one true God instead of following those false beliefs.

Exodus 20:3-17

The terms of the covenant (promises between God and his people) describe how the people were

expected to behave if they were to be in a covenant with God. The first four instructions relate directly to God ([20:2-11](#)). The last six are about relationships between people ([20:12-17](#)).

A covenant with God explains how we should treat one another. God is deeply concerned with what is right and wrong. He expects his people to show his character in all their relationships.

Other law codes in the ancient Near East did not include such strong and absolute commands. This may be because polytheism (belief in many gods) does not support one clear and final standard for everyone.

In contrast, covenants made with a human king often included absolute commands. A single king could demand complete obedience from his subjects.

In Israel's covenant, the one King is the Creator of the universe. He alone has the full authority to declare what is right and wrong. Because of who he is, he can give absolute principles, commands, and prohibitions.

Exodus 20:4

Refusing to make an image of God is the first step in recognizing that he is transcendent. This means God is the Creator of the universe and is completely distinct from it. God is not part of creation.

If people represent God as something in creation, they will eventually worship that created thing. Instead of worshiping the Creator, they begin to worship what God made.

This exchange leads to moral corruption and spiritual harm ([Romans 1:18-25](#)).

Exodus 20:5-6

- *jealous God*: When Scripture calls God a jealous God, it means he strongly opposes his people turning to false gods. He does not want them to give their loyalty to other gods (see [Joshua 24:19-20](#)). God's jealousy is not selfish. It shows his deep love and his desire for his people to remain faithful to him.
- *to the third and fourth generations ... a thousand generations*: We must understand both parts of this statement together. God does not punish children for the sins of their parents. Instead, God teaches that sin has effects that can harm future generations. Even so, God limits the natural effects of sin to three or four generations. In contrast, he extends the effects of obedience to a thousand generations. This shows that God's mercy is much greater than his judgment (see also [34:6-7](#); [Deuteronomy 7:9](#)).
- *hate*: The Hebrew words translated "love" ([Exodus 20:6](#)) and "hate" are broader than English words. They describe not only feelings but also choices. In the Bible, to *love* means "to choose someone or something and to act faithfully toward that choice." To *hate* means "to reject someone or something and to act in ways that show that rejection." Emotions and choices are connected. What we feel influences our choices, and our choices reveal what we truly feel.

Exodus 20:7

In Hebrew thought, a person's name is often closely connected to that person's nature and character (see study note on [3:13-22](#)). To misuse God's name means to make God seem unimportant or worthless. One way to do this is by swearing an

oath using God's name without intending to keep it. But there are other, more serious ways to dishonor God's name (see [Numbers 20:12](#); [Amos 2:7](#); compare [Matthew 6:9](#)).

Exodus 20:8-11

The Sabbath day is holy when dedicated to the Lord ([20:10](#)). What belongs only to God shares his character. This does not mean the other six days are unholy. They are for regular work ([20:9](#)). On this special day, we remember that our work does not meet our needs. God provides for us through his grace ([20:6](#)).

Exodus 20:11

To be in covenant with God is to do what God does. Since God rested from his work, we must also rest ([Genesis 2:1-3](#)).

Exodus 20:12

honor your father and mother: This means acknowledging that you rely on others. This is an important step toward humility. Arrogance might make you famous, but humility and gratitude lead to a long, fulfilling life.

Both Jesus and the apostle Paul refer to this command (see [Matthew 15:4](#); [Mark 7:10](#); [Ephesians 6:1-3](#)).

Exodus 20:12-17

The last six instructions focus on relationships between people. Many parts of God's covenant teach how people should treat one another.

In Israel, right behavior toward others was closely connected to worship. Obeying God meant treating other people in ways that reflect his character.

This connection between ethics (moral behavior) and religious duty was unusual in the ancient world. Several law codes existed in the ancient Near East, and some were written before Moses. However, those laws came from human kings and were not closely connected to worship.

In contrast, the false gods of other nations were described as immoral and untrustworthy. The God

of Israel is different. His people honor him by treating others as he treats them. See also [Matthew 19:17–19](#).

Exodus 20:13

murder: This does not refer to every act of killing. The Hebrew language has another word that can mean killing in a more general sense.

The command does not forbid *all* taking of human life in every situation. Instead, it forbids the intentional killing of another person for personal reasons.

This command shows that God values each person's physical life. Jesus later expanded this teaching in [Matthew 5:21–26](#).

Exodus 20:14

adultery: This includes all sexual sins. Adultery clearly shows what it means to break trust or be unfaithful.

When a person commits adultery, that person seeks sexual pleasure outside of marriage and breaks trust with a spouse.

This command teaches faithfulness in marriage and purity in sexual behavior. Jesus later expanded this teaching in [Matthew 5:27–30](#).

Exodus 20:15

Stealing shows an attitude that says, "I have the right to take what I want." It ignores whether something belongs to someone else or whether it was earned honestly.

This command teaches the opposite attitude. It teaches respect for other people and for what belongs to them.

From God's point of view, this command shows that he values each person. God cares not only about our lives but also about the things that belong to us.

Exodus 20:16

Choosing not to tell a lie can sometimes be a private act. A person might even feel proud about being honest.

However, this command is more specific. It forbids giving false testimony against your neighbor. This refers especially to lying in court or in a public setting where someone's reputation or life may be at risk.

Refusing to testify falsely is an unselfish act. It shows that you care more about your neighbor's reputation and well-being than about protecting yourself or gaining an advantage.

Exodus 20:17

This final principle circles back to the first, for "a greedy person is an idolater" ([Col 3:5](#)). Covetousness is the worship of this world, the belief that possessions, especially those my neighbor possesses, will give me lasting happiness. To believe this is to break one's covenant of absolute loyalty to God, who alone supplies our needs. See also [Rom 7:7](#).

Exodus 20:18–21

The people were very conscious of their sinfulness before a holy God and begged Moses to stand between them and God. Moses pointed out that God's goal was neither to overawe them nor to destroy them. Rather, he wanted their awe of him to keep them from sinning ([20:20](#)). Jesus is the ultimate mediator between God and people ([1 Tim 2:5](#)).

Exodus 20:18–26

This interlude is about access to God. The first part ([20:18–21](#)) deals with the need for a mediator between the people and God. In [20:22–26](#), we find the appropriate form for an altar in the interval before God revealed his plans for a more permanent sanctuary (see [25:1–30:28](#)).

Exodus 20:22–26

The Lord is transcendent, as shown by his speaking to the people in a disembodied voice from heaven ([20:22](#)). This would have two effects upon their practice: They were not to use silver or gold to make gods in human form (idols, [20:23](#)), and they were not to carve stones for an altar ([20:25](#)).

Perhaps this is because they would be tempted to carve stone gods in the process. The altar was to be made of earth ([20:24](#)) and uncut stones ([20:25](#)). • The prohibition against revealing one's nakedness ([20:26](#)) might have been to separate Israelite religious practice from the nature worship around them. Sexual activity was an integral part of many Canaanite rituals.

Exodus 21:1–11

Slavery was a fact of life in the ancient world. In some cases, it was the only resort for those who were destitute. In much of the ancient world, people who were slaves felt that the gods had abandoned them. But the Lord cares about those who are in this helpless condition, so his covenant people must care also. Ultimately, the revelation that Jesus Christ had died for all people everywhere would make the practice of slavery untenable ([Gal 3:28](#)).

Exodus 21:1–23.19

The statements found here are in the typical case-law format of ancient Near Eastern law codes. This format begins with a hypothetical situation introduced by the word “if.” The following statement of what is to be done in such a case is introduced by “then.” While some cases are grouped into categories in these chapters, there is little attempt to separate personal, civil, or ceremonial laws from one another. For God, life is not compartmentalized. All of life is lived in relationship to God, so all kinds of behavior signify whether we are in loving submission to him or in defiance of him.

Exodus 21:1–23.33

The terms of the covenant are now expanded. The beginning section ([21:1–23:19](#)) gives specific examples of the general principles stated in [20:3–17](#). The commitments to which God bound himself if the Israelites kept their side of the covenant are stated in [23:20–33](#), as are the blessings of obedience.

Exodus 21:2

A man might sell himself into slavery in order to get money to pay his debts. This law states that the man was never to become the permanent property of the master.

Exodus 21:3

If a man and a wife went into slavery together, they were also to go free together.

Exodus 21:4–6

The master was not required to provide a slave with a wife who would then be freed with him. The slave in such a situation had to either abandon the family he began while he was a slave or become a permanent slave.

Exodus 21:7–9

A female slave was treated differently from a male slave. She may have been sold with the expectation that she would become a concubine (a secondary wife). Releasing her after seven years would not necessarily protect her.

If she were sent away, she might have to return to her father. Her father had already sold her, which suggests he did not want her. Marriage would also be unlikely for a former concubine. She might even be forced into prostitution. For this reason, it was often considered better for her to remain in her master's household.

Sometimes a man bought a girl to become his son's wife ([21:9](#)). In that case, the payment was not the price of a slave. It was similar to a bride-price (a gift given to a bride's family at marriage). In the ancient Near East, a young man usually gave money or valuable gifts to the bride's father (see [22:16](#); [Genesis 24:53](#)). A woman for whom a bride-price had been paid was not considered a slave.

Exodus 21:12–17

The crimes of murder, kidnapping, and cursing or striking one's parents were punished by death. A person who committed murder gave up his own

right to live. Human life is very precious in God's sight.

Even when a death was accidental, it could not simply be ignored. However, the law made a difference between murder and accidental killing.

God provided places of refuge (see [Numbers 35:6–28](#)). These were special towns where a person who killed someone by accident could flee. There, the family of the dead person could not take revenge (see also study notes on Numbers 35:6–34).

Exodus 21:14

take him away from My altar: See [1 Kings 2:28–33](#).

Exodus 21:17

Anyone who curses: See study note on Leviticus 20:9; see also [Exodus 20:12](#); [Deuteronomy 5:16](#); [21:18–21](#); [Ephesians 6:1–4](#).

Exodus 21:18–27

These laws governed compensation for injuries that did not lead to death.

Exodus 21:22–25

so she gives birth prematurely: It appears that if a child's birth was caused prematurely and the child died (i.e., there was further injury), the penalty for murder was to be enacted. The law of retaliation (the *lex talionis*) called for a penalty that matched the injury inflicted on a victim. But this law also served to limit the punishment so it was not more severe than the original injury. Cp. [Matt 5:38–39](#).

Exodus 21:28–32

If an animal caused a person's death and the owner was judged to be negligent, the relatives of the deceased could demand the death penalty for both the animal and its owner. However, that penalty was not mandatory, and the relatives could elect to accept compensation ([21:30](#)).

Exodus 21:33–22:15

In cases involving loss of property, the responsible person had to pay compensation equal to the value of what was lost. If the person had actually stolen the property, the compensation was multiplied ([22:1](#), [4](#), [7](#)). Where there was a question of responsibility, the parties were to appear before God for adjudication ([22:8](#)). The means by which the judgment was reached is not reported.

Exodus 22:16–31

These laws deal with different situations about social responsibility. They are not arranged in clear groups or categories.

These laws show that every part of life relates to obedience to God. Obedience to God is not limited to worship. It includes daily actions and relationships (see study note on 21:1–23:19).

Exodus 22:18

The practices of a sorceress (a woman who uses magic or calls on spirits) reflected the pagan worldview (a way of understanding life that does not follow the true God). God was rescuing his people from this way of thinking and living.

This worldview was completely different from the biblical one. The Lord had already commanded his people not to worship other gods (see [20:3](#); [23:13](#)).

Exodus 22:20

he must be set apart for destruction: See the "Complete Dedication" Theme Note.

Exodus 22:21

The Hebrews were to treat foreigners kindly because they, too, had once been foreigners (see also [23:9](#); [Deuteronomy 10:18–19](#)). For more on this principle, see [Luke 6:31](#).

Exodus 22:22–23

The widow, the orphan, and the foreigner were in a helpless and economically disadvantaged position.

God, by his protective stance toward these persons, demonstrated that he does not value people on the basis of their power or wealth, the standards accepted by most humans. Instead, God values people because they share his image ([Gen 1:27](#)).

Exodus 22:25-27

Although interest could not be charged on a loan to another Israelite, collateral, or security, could be required. However, even the security had to be handled in a humane way. The requirements of the covenant mirrored the character of God.

Exodus 22:30

God is considerate even of animals (see [Jonah 4:11](#)).

Exodus 22:31

In the Bible, blood has symbolic meaning because it represents life. For this reason, God forbade people to eat meat that still had blood in it (see [Leviticus 17:10-16](#)).

Exodus 23:1-3

It is important to speak the truth, even when facing evil people, a crowd, or misguided motives ([23:1](#), [2](#), [3](#), [7-8](#)).

Exodus 23:1-9

This call for justice includes a mixed list of covenant requirements. Most of these requirements deal with fairness and honesty in daily life. They show how God's people should treat others with integrity.

Exodus 23:7

God's character inspires people to act righteously (see [22:22-24](#), [27](#)).

Exodus 23:10-12

Renewal, rest, and refreshment are important ([23:12](#)). Just as humans and animals are to enjoy these in the weekly Sabbath, so the land is to be given rest every seven years ([23:10-11](#); see study note on [20:8-11](#)).

Exodus 23:14-17

God commanded that every man in Israel must appear before him three times each year ([23:17](#)). They must appear at the tabernacle (also called the *Tent of Meeting*). While Israel camped around the Tent of Meeting in the wilderness, this command was not difficult to obey. The people lived close to the tabernacle.

Later, after Israel settled in the promised land, many people lived far from the Tent of Meeting and later from the temple in Jerusalem. Travel became longer and more demanding.

This command was likely meant to prevent the people from building local worship centers. If each region created its own place of worship, the nation could become divided.

Local shrines could also allow pagan influences (beliefs and practices from other religions) to enter the worship of Yahweh. By gathering at one central place, the people would remain united in their worship of the one true God.

Sadly, the people did not always carry out these commands carefully (see, for example, [2 Kings 23:21-23](#)).

Exodus 23:15

At the appointed time in the month of Abib: See [13:4-5](#); [Leviticus 23:5-8](#); [Deuteronomy 16:1-8](#).

Exodus 23:16

- They celebrated *the Feast of Harvest* seven weeks after Passover. This was about the end of the barley harvest and the start of the wheat harvest (mid-May to mid-June). In later Judaism, this feast marked the giving of the covenant at Mount Sinai. This happened 50 days after the first Passover in Egypt (see [Leviticus 23:15–21](#); [Deuteronomy 16:9–12](#)).
- They celebrated the Feast of the Ingathering on the fifteenth day of the seventh month of the Hebrew calendar (mid-September to mid-October). This was after the grape harvest ended. This feast remembered the time in the wilderness when God provided for his people.

Exodus 23:18

Blood symbolized life ([Lev 17:11–14](#); [Deut 12:23](#)), so blood must not be mixed with yeast, which was not normally included in offerings (see study note on [Lev 2:11](#)). • The fat, considered the best part of the offering, was to be burned at once (see [Lev 3:3–5](#)).

Exodus 23:19

The significance of the command not to cook a young goat in its mother's milk is unknown. Its inclusion at this point suggests that it may have been a pagan religious practice.

Exodus 23:20–23

an angel: Probably "the angel of the LORD," often representing God himself (see [3:2](#)).

Exodus 23:20–33

If the people obeyed the covenant rules, God promised to protect them from enemies and illness and give them land to own ([23:22–23](#), [25–26](#), [27–](#)

[31](#)). These promises depended on complete loyalty to God (Yahweh). Worshiping the gods of the peoples expelled from the land would be an act of rebellion ([23:21](#); [24](#), [32–33](#)).

Exodus 23:24

In Canaanite worship, people built holy pillars to represent the gods. Sometimes, they carved them to look like humans.

Exodus 23:26

Pagan rites were carried out in an attempt to manipulate the forces of fertility and reproduction. God promised to give these gifts freely if the people would faithfully carry out the terms of their covenant with him.

Exodus 23:29–31

I will: God, not Israel, would take the land. The land would be a gift from their Covenant Lord. Israel was being granted possession of it as long as they faithfully fulfilled the covenant.

Exodus 23:31

from the eastern wilderness to the Euphrates River: See [Gen 15:18](#); [Num 34:2–12](#); [Deut 11:24](#); [2 Chr 9:26](#). • I will hand over to you the people: God had promised the land to Abraham ([Gen 15:16](#)). At that time, "the sins of the Amorites" had not yet run their course. Now they had. God was not arbitrarily dispossessing the Amorites (i.e., the Canaanites) but was using his people, the Israelites, to judge their wickedness.

Exodus 23:33

they will cause you to sin against me: The Canaanites were to be destroyed because there could be no truce between a holy God and sin. Furthermore, the continuance of God's revelation, which was to culminate in the incarnation of Jesus Christ, depended on the survival of that revelation through the people of Israel. If they fell back into paganism, that could not happen.

Exodus 24:1-2

Some commentators suggest that Moses, Aaron, Nadab, Abihu, and the elders made two trips up the mountain, here and in [24:9-11](#). However, this command was probably given in advance and obeyed at the proper time in [24:9](#).

Exodus 24:1-18

Israel agreed to the terms of the covenant ([24:3](#)), which was then ratified in several ceremonial activities. This included the formal writing and reading of the covenant ([24:4, 7](#)), the splattering of blood ([24:6](#)), a covenant meal ([24:11](#)), and the appearing of the glory of the Lord on the mountain ([24:15-18](#)).

Exodus 24:3

went down: At this critical moment, would the people accept this relationship with God in which they would swear absolute loyalty to him and agree to live in ways that are in keeping with his character? Fortunately, they answered unanimously, with one voice, that they would abide by the covenant.

Exodus 24:4

Pillars were erected as historical markers, witnessing in history that something momentous had occurred at a certain time at this place. In Hittite treaties, pagan gods were called upon to witness the agreement. In this case, the Hebrews were forbidden to recognize other gods, so pillars served the purpose.

Exodus 24:6

When Moses splattered half of the blood of the sacrificial animals against the altar, he symbolized God's formal oath to keep the covenant (see [Gen 15:9-18](#); [Heb 6:13](#)).

Exodus 24:7

Treaties were required to be written down and publicly read . . . aloud. Very likely Moses began at this time to write down, under God's inspiration, all the things that he believed were authoritative documents for his people.

Exodus 24:8

Look, this blood confirms the covenant (literally *behold the blood of the covenant*): Jesus repeated this sentence almost verbatim at the Last Supper ([Matt 26:28](#)), when he said, "This is my blood, which confirms the covenant" (literally "*This is my blood of the covenant*"). See also [Heb 9:20](#).

Exodus 24:10

There they saw . . . God: This statement must be interpreted in the light of [33:20](#). They saw some representation of God, the description of which is limited to the surface under his feet. When Isaiah saw God, the only description given was of the hem of his robe ([Isa 6:1](#)).

Exodus 24:11

In places around the world, eating a meal together often indicates peace and good relationships. This is true both in the past and today.

Exodus 24:12

The instructions and commands to be inscribed on the tablets of stone were the ten basic principles of [20:3-17](#) (see [34:28](#)) on which the specific stipulations of [21:1-23:33](#) depended.

Exodus 24:17

consuming fire: See [3:2](#) and the study note.

Exodus 25:1-27.19

These instructions first indicate the materials the Israelites could contribute for the construction of the Tabernacle ([25:3-7](#)). The instructions then

move from the center outward, beginning with the Ark of the Covenant ([25:10–22](#)) and concluding with the courtyard ([27:9–19](#)). Two items, the altar of incense in the sanctuary and the washbasin in the courtyard, are included later ([30:1–10](#), [17–21](#)), in the section relating to the priesthood, perhaps because their use was especially related to functions of the priests.

Exodus 25:1–40:38

Unlike most churches today, the Tent of Meeting (the tabernacle) was not mainly a place where people gathered to meet. It was first of all the dwelling place of God. It functioned like the palace of a king. God was Israel's divine King, and the Tabernacle was his royal tent.

In this way, churches today are more similar to later Jewish synagogues, where people gathered to worship and learn (see also study note on 40:2).

The last section of Exodus completes God's self-revelation to Israel. Through these events, God brought the people out of the spiritual darkness that had held them in slavery.

This section includes three main parts:

1. Instructions for building the Tent of Meeting (chapters [25–31](#)).
2. The story of the golden calf (a wrong attempt to secure God's presence, chapters [32–34](#)).
3. The report of building the Tent of Meeting (the correct way to secure God's presence, chapters [35–40](#)).

These chapters show that God's ultimate goal in delivering Israel from slavery was to live among them.

God wanted to share his presence with his people. However, because God is holy (completely pure and set apart from sin), people could experience his presence only in the way he commanded.

They could not approach him through pagan practices (worship methods of other nations) or through human manipulation (trying to control or force a god to act).

The building of the Tent of Meeting is described here, even though some instructions in Leviticus were given earlier (see [40:1–2](#); [Leviticus 25:1](#); [27:34](#); [Numbers 7:1](#)). This event shows the goal of

the entire exodus story: God came to live among his people.

Exodus 25:2

every man whose heart compels him: There is a plain difference between meeting needs in God's way and trying to meet them on our own. For example, Aaron forced people to contribute to making the gold calf (see [32:1–4](#)).

Exodus 25:8

- *a sanctuary:* For the people to have a life-giving relationship with God, they needed to understand how completely different God was from them (see study note on 3:5).
- The purpose of this activity was so God could live among them.

Exodus 25:9

according to the pattern: We cannot choose how to approach a holy God. We must meet God on his terms and in accord with his desires and character.

Exodus 25:10–22

an Ark of acacia wood: In translating the plans for the Ark of the Covenant, the NLT continues to use the word Ark because of its traditional associations. However, *ark* is simply an archaic English word meaning “box.” The Ark was Israel's “covenant box.” It was the most significant item in the whole complex, because it was there that God made his presence available ([25:22](#)). The presence of the stone tablets of the covenant in the box ([25:16](#), [21](#)) underlined the truth that God reveals himself in the context of a mutually binding commitment between himself and his people.

Exodus 25:12–15

The carrying poles were there so that no one would touch this representation of God's devastating holiness. Later, a death occurred when someone

instinctively reached out to steady the Ark as it was being moved from one place to another (see [2 Sam 6:6-7](#)).

Exodus 25:17

The Hebrew word translated as *mercy seat* means "a covering." The cover of the covenant box was where God "covered over" sin (see [Leviticus 16:14-16](#)).

Exodus 25:18

The description of the *cherubim* only mentions that they had wings ([25:20](#); see [2 Chronicles 3:10-13](#)).

Exodus 25:22

I will meet with you there: The Ark was located in the innermost part of the sanctuary ([26:33](#)), which was in effect God's throne room (see study note on Lev 16:2). In a comparable pagan sanctuary, one would find an idol in this location. The Tabernacle had no idol, only a box that physically represented the covenant faithfulness and grace of God. God meets his people in that context, not in the context of idolatry. An idol reflects the belief that a deity is continuous with the created order and that it can be manipulated with the right ritual. It assumes that we can secure blessings from the deity without regard to our own character or commitment. But God is completely distinct from this world, and he cannot be manipulated in any way. He wants to bless us, but those blessings can only be given to those who receive his grace as a gift and surrender to him in trust.

Exodus 25:23-30

The table of acacia wood stood on the north side of the main room of the sanctuary, the Holy Place ([26:35](#)). It reminded the people that God would provide sustenance for them. Above all, that sustenance was his presence ([25:30](#)).

Exodus 25:29

The drink offerings included olive oil and wine (see [29:40](#)).

Exodus 25:31-39

The lampstand of pure, hammered gold stood on the south side of the Holy Place ([26:35](#)). It showed the light of God's presence to his people. The lamps ([25:37](#)) were flat dishes containing olive oil. A wick extended into the oil and hung down from a lip on one side of the dish. The dishes, resting on the upturned almond blossoms ([25:33](#)), were to be turned so that all their wicks faced the center of the room ([25:37](#)). The total number of lamps is not clear. Although seven lamps are mentioned in [25:37](#), there seem to be 22 lamp cups in [25:33-34](#).

Exodus 26:1-37

The tabernacle itself (not including the courtyard around it) was not very large. It was about 4.6 meters (15 feet) wide and 13.7 meters (45 feet) long.

The main structure stood on 48 vertical frames. Each frame was 4.6 meters (15 feet) high and 68.6 centimeters (27 inches) wide ([26:16](#)). The frames were made of acacia wood and covered with gold ([26:15, 29](#)).

Workers joined the frames together with horizontal crossbars. These bars formed a three-sided rectangle with one open end ([26:26-28](#)).

Two large linen curtains covered the structure. Each large curtain was made from five smaller curtains joined together. The two large curtains were then connected into one long covering ([26:1-6](#)).

This linen covering stretched across the top of the frame. It hung down along the sides and the back. It covered both the walls and the roof.

Over the linen curtain, workers placed another curtain made of goat hair. It was built in the same way. This curtain was 0.9 meters (3 feet) wider and 1.8 meters (6 feet) longer than the linen curtain ([26:7-13](#)). Because it was larger, it hung lower on every side.

Above these two curtains were two protective layers. One layer was made from tanned ram skins. The other was made from fine leather ([26:14](#)). These outer coverings protected the tabernacle from weather and damage.

Inside the tabernacle, another curtain divided the space into two parts. This curtain was beautifully embroidered. It hung across the width of the structure on four posts made of acacia wood ([26:31-33](#)). This created two rooms. The first room was called the Holy Place. The second room was called the Most Holy Place.

Exodus 26:2-6

The cloth was 13 meters long (42 feet) and two meters wide (six feet). The width of two meters (six feet) may have been because of the largest loom available. They joined five of these six-foot strips, probably by sewing, to create one continuous piece of cloth 13 meters long (42 feet) and 10 meters wide (30 feet). When connected with loops and clasps, the two cloths formed a single unit measuring 13 meters (42 feet) by 20 meters (60 feet) ([26:5-6](#)).

Exodus 26:9

The two goat-hair curtains measured about 14 meters (45 feet) by 20 meters (66 feet) ([26:7](#)). The extra two meters (six feet) hung evenly over the front and back of the structure.

Exodus 26:15

acacia wood: This is a hard wood found in the region of Sinai.

Exodus 26:19

Each base was under the place where the frames joined. The right peg of one frame and the left peg of the next frame fit into one base. Along with the crossbars, this setup helped stabilize the entire structure ([26:27-28](#)).

Exodus 26:31

Blue, purple, and scarlet are rich colors suitable for the palace of God the king. God may have chosen these dyes because they were easy to find in the desert.

Exodus 26:33

The Most Holy Place was the earthly dwelling of God. It held the ark of the covenant, where the Lord gave commands to the people of Israel ([25:22](#)). The Most Holy Place was about 4.5 meters (15 feet) wide, 4.5 meters (15 feet) deep, and 4.5 meters (15 feet) high.

Exodus 26:36-37

The curtain at the eastern end was like the one between the Holy Place and the Most Holy Place. The posts had bronze bases, not silver ones.

Exodus 27:1-8

The square altar for burnt offerings, like the tabernacle frames, was made of acacia wood covered with metal. Yet, to match the other features outside the sanctuary, they covered it with bronze ([27:2-3](#); see [27:10](#), [17](#), [19](#)).

Exodus 27:1-19

The plans for the altar of burnt offering and the courtyard extend outward from the center. Like the sanctuary, the plans for the courtyard's furniture are provided before the courtyard itself ([27:1-8](#); [27:9-19](#)).

Exodus 27:2

Archaeology shows that the horns of the altar were raised parts at the four corners of the altar. They projected upward from each corner.

These horns may have helped keep the wood and offerings from falling off the altar (see [Psalm 118:27](#)). They also had meaning related to beliefs about God. The horns represented God's gracious care for his people.

If a person held onto the horns of the altar, that person was asking for mercy in judgment (see [1 Kings 1:50-51](#); [2:28](#)). This action showed a request for protection or leniency.

The priests put blood on the horns during atonement and purification ceremonies (special rituals to deal with sin and uncleanness; see [Exodus 29:12](#); [Leviticus 4:7](#)).

Exodus 27:5

The altar was evidently a hollow square ([27:1, 8](#)), with the grating placed inside it to allow ashes to fall to the ground underneath.

Exodus 27:9-19

The courtyard plans included curtain walls made of finely woven linen, hanging on posts with bronze bases. The posts were 2.29 meters apart (7.5 feet) and 2.29 meters high (7.5 feet). The curtains formed a rectangle measuring 46 meters long (150 feet) and 22.86 meters wide (75 feet), with a 10-meter opening (30 feet) centered on the east side.

Exodus 27:16

The curtain covering the gate of the courtyard was similar in color and design to the entrance and dividing curtains of the tabernacle ([Exodus 26:31, 36](#)).

Exodus 27:19

The use of tent pegs indicates that the courtyard posts were not freestanding. Support wires stabilized them.

Exodus 27:20-21

The first thing said about the function of the priests, Aaron and his sons, is that they were to keep the lamps burning continually through the night (see [30:8](#)). As the lamps burned before the Lord, they showed that God was still present with his people. The light reminded them that his presence continued among them.

Exodus 27:20-30:38

After explaining how to build the Tent of Meeting, Moses gave instructions for those serving in it and the items used. Included are:

- the priests' duties ([27:20-21](#); [29:38-46](#)),
- the priests' clothing (chapter [28](#)),
- the ceremonies to set the priests apart for service ([29:1-37](#)),
- the tabernacle furnishings ([30:1-10, 17-21](#)), and
- the supplies used for worship ([30:11-16, 22-38](#)).

Exodus 27:21

the Tent of Meeting: The expression *Tent of Meeting* sometimes refers to the tabernacle tent. In these cases, *Tent of Meeting* and *tabernacle* mean the same thing.

In addition, [33:7-11](#) also mentions a temporary tent called the *Tent of Meeting*. This tent was set up outside the camp before the tabernacle was built. See study note on 40:2.

Exodus 28:1-2

The garments described in this chapter are primarily those for Aaron, the first high priest. The clothing for Aaron's sons, who functioned as his assistants, is described in [28:40-43](#).

Exodus 28:1-43

These glorious and beautiful ([28:2](#)) garments for Aaron were to distinguish him as a priest set apart (Hebrew *qadash*, "consecrated") for [the Lord's] service ([28:3](#)). The magnificence of these garments is in keeping with the grandeur of the Tabernacle, which functioned as a portable earthly palace for God. There would come a day when Jesus Christ, the true High Priest, would enter the Most Holy Place once for all, and the distinction between priests and people would fade away ([Heb 10:11-22](#)). Until that time, human mediators were needed to symbolize the wonderful thing that God was planning to do in the hearts, lives, and behaviors of those with whom he shared his presence.

Exodus 28:6–14

The ephod was a kind of apron consisting of front and back pieces joined by shoulder straps ([28:7](#)) and secured by a decorative sash ([28:8](#), [27–28](#)). Perhaps it is mentioned first because it was understood to be the distinctive high priestly garment. The fact that Gideon later made a gold ephod ([Judg 8:27](#)) suggests that the garment was thought to have special powers.

Exodus 28:12

names on his shoulders (cp. [Isa 9:6](#)): The badge of office on the shoulder indicated what the person was really carrying. Thus, the high priest represented the people before God, and with his royal garments he represented the glory of God before the people.

Exodus 28:15–30

More attention is given to the chestpiece than to any other item, suggesting the importance attached to it. It apparently symbolized the priest's representation of Israel ([28:17–21](#), [29](#)) and was a container for the Urim and Thummim, by which God made his will known ([28:30](#)). The chestpiece represented the totality of the high priest's tasks of bringing the people to God and bringing God's word to the people.

Exodus 28:29

The high priest would go into the Holy Place (the outer room of the sanctuary) to trim the lamp, replace the bread on the table, and replenish the incense on the altar that stood outside the Most Holy Place.

Exodus 28:30

The Urim and Thummim (Hebrew terms that might translate as *lights* [or *curses*] and *perfections*) were apparently a pair of stones that were thrown down to get a yes or no answer from God. No physical description of these objects exists; their use is further explained in [Num 27:21](#); [Deut 33:8](#); [1 Sam 28:6](#); [Ezra 2:63](#); and [Neh 7:65](#).

Exodus 28:31–35

The robe worn under the ephod is described. The bells signaled that the priest was still moving and had not been struck dead by God's presence (see [Lev 10:1–2](#)). Jewish tradition tells us that the priest had a cord tied to his ankle so that if he died in the Holy Place ([Exod 28:35](#)), his body could be dragged out.

Exodus 28:36–38

Like all other parts of the high priest's clothing and actions, the little gold plate on the front of his turban reminded the people that God is holy. His holiness affected how they could enter his presence. God wanted to live with his people, but his holiness would harm them unless he took protective measures. God decides how we can enter his presence, not us.

The Bible's main question is how sinful people can live with a holy God so that God can share his holy character with them. Jesus Christ, the Holy One of God, provides the answer. He is the perfect mediator ([Luke 4:34](#); [Hebrews 9:11–15](#)). He did not die only to save us from the consequences of our sins. He died so that God can live in us and create his holy character in us ([Ephesians 2:10; 4:22](#); [Philippians 1:27](#); [1 Peter 1:13–16](#)).

Exodus 28:39

The tunic was probably a shirt worn under the robe (see [29:5](#)).

Exodus 28:42–43

In many pagan religions, sexual acts were part of worship. People believed they could control fertility (the ability to have children, crops, and animals) through sexual activity.

In some places, priests even served their gods without clothing. These practices were attempts to influence the powers of nature.

In the worship of the Lord, no form of sexual manipulation was allowed. God's blessings cannot be gained through magical actions or human control.

For this reason, even the accidental exposure of the genitals was carefully avoided. Worship of the Lord had to reflect his holiness and purity.

Exodus 29:1

with no defects: The same word is translated “blameless” and “perfect” in reference to human and divine behavior (e.g., [Gen 17:1](#); [Ps 18:30, 32](#)). The sacrifice is representative of God’s own character and the character he seeks in humans.

Exodus 29:1–37

Moses was required to consecrate (or *sanctify*) Aaron and his sons to serve the Lord. This emphasis on making the priests holy is found throughout the ceremonies ([29:6, 21, 28, 29, 34, 36, 37](#)). They were set apart not merely for service, but to serve a God whose nature is utterly different from that of fallen, sinful humans. The report of how these instructions were carried out is found in [Lev 8](#).

Exodus 29:4

wash them with water: This action showed an important truth. No one can live in God’s presence while carrying the filth of sin in their lives ([29:21](#)).

The washing did not remove sin by itself. It was a sign. It showed that people must be made clean before coming near to God.

Exodus 29:7

The anointing oil empowered a person for a task through the Holy Spirit (see [Isaiah 61:1](#)).

Exodus 29:9

forever: The fulfillment of this promise, as with the one to David, clearly leads beyond the merely human. Aaron’s own behavior was less than sterling (e.g., [ch 32](#); [Num 11](#)), and the behavior of his sons and descendants was no better ([1 Sam 2:12–17](#); [Isa 28:7](#); [Ezek 8:15–16](#); [Mal 2:1–9](#)). The promise could only find its ultimate fulfillment in Jesus Christ (see [Heb 7:26](#); [9:11](#)). • To ordain

(literally *to fill the hands*) means to give a person a task to perform.

Exodus 29:10–34

The consecration of the priesthood of Aaron involved a sin offering ([29:10–14](#)), a burnt offering ([29:15–18](#)), and an ordination offering ([29:19–28](#)). The same patterns established here are expanded to the regular offerings of the people (see [29:38–46](#); [Lev 1–5](#)). In all three cases, Aaron and his sons lay their hands on [the] head of the sacrificial animals ([Exod 29:10, 15, 19](#)), indicating that sin is a matter of life and death, and that it can only be removed by a death. Because it represents life, blood is prominent in these ceremonies ([29:12, 16, 20, 21](#)).

Exodus 29:13

The fat was considered the best part and so was given to God.

Exodus 29:14

- The remains stood for what was unclean in human behavior. They symbolized actions and attitudes that were sinful or morally impure.
- *sin offering*: See [Leviticus 4](#).

Exodus 29:15–18

The next offering was a gift of thanks to God. It also represented fully dedicating oneself to God.

Exodus 29:18

pleasing aroma: Such language is *anthropomorphism*, describing God with human terms and experiences. God’s delight in an appropriately offered sacrifice is like a human’s enjoyment of a pleasing smell.

Exodus 29:19–28

This ordination offering is very similar to the peace (or fellowship) offering later described in [Lev 3](#). The fat was burned as a gift to the Lord, but the breast and the thigh, after having been dedicated to the Lord by lifting them up before him ([29:24–26](#)), became the portion for the priests to eat ([29:26–28](#)). In the regular peace offering, the remainder of the meat was to be eaten by the person making the offering in a fellowship meal ([Lev 7:11–18](#)), as the priests did here ([Exod 29:31–34](#)).

Exodus 29:20–21

The placing of the blood on the earlobes, thumbs, and big toes represented dedication of the entire person to God. Sprinkling it on their clothes indicated that the clothing, too, could be used only for holy purposes.

Exodus 29:30

The son who succeeds him: Each high priest who came after him had to be ordained in the same way. Ordained means formally set apart and appointed for holy service.

Exodus 29:31

This holy place was probably in the courtyard of the tabernacle.

Exodus 29:32–34

Eating in the presence of the Lord showed a close relationship with him (as in [24:9–11](#)).

Exodus 29:33

atonement: Traditionally, *atonement* has often been explained as a “covering over.” This means that sin is covered so it no longer stands between God and people.

Some modern scholars connect the word to another Semitic root (a related word family from ancient Middle Eastern languages). That root does not appear elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible. Based

on that idea, they understand the word to mean “blot out,” “erase,” or “cleanse.”

In both views, the result is the same. The effects of sin are removed. Because of this, people and even sacred objects can remain in God’s presence without being destroyed.

Exodus 29:37

As with the priests, the altar was to be made holy so it could be used in service of the holy God.

Exodus 29:38–41

Offering the daily sacrifices was one of the chief functions of the priest.

Exodus 29:42–46

The purpose of the Tabernacle, the priesthood, and the sacrificial system was to facilitate human fellowship with God. The Lord would meet with his people there ([29:42](#), [43](#)) and speak with them ([29:42](#)). He would live among them as their God ([29:45](#), [46](#)).

Exodus 29:46

The purpose of the Exodus was to reveal the grace, power, and holiness of God and to enable humans to experience God’s presence in their lives.

Exodus 30:1–10

Plans for the altar of acacia wood are included here rather than with the plans for the other items in the sanctuary ([25:23–40](#)), perhaps because of the reference to the priest’s use of it in [30:7–10](#).

Exodus 30:6

outside the inner curtain: That is, in the Holy Place, just outside the Most Holy Place where the Ark was located. • The rising smoke of the incense symbolized prayer. Believers now have constant access to God in prayer through the continuous

atonement provided through Christ (see [Ps 141:2](#); [Luke 1:10](#); [Rev 5:8](#); [8:3–4](#)).

Exodus 30:12

no plague: Cp. [2 Sam 24](#), when a plague followed upon David's unauthorized census. Perhaps a census was often taken for reasons of pride and domination. Here the people are giving God a ransom for themselves. This standard payment would go into the Tabernacle treasury and initially be used in the construction of the Tabernacle (see [Exod 38:25–26](#)).

Exodus 30:17–21

On why the plans for the bronze washbasin are included here, see study note on 30:1–10.

Exodus 30:22–38

Because God is absolutely unique (holy), what is used for his service cannot be used for any other purpose. This was the point made to Moses at the burning bush (see study note on 3:5). It was so important for the people to understand this that disobedience in this matter involved a severe punishment ([30:33](#)).

Exodus 30:33

cut off from his people: Either by death or by expulsion. In some cases, God brought death as a direct judgment. In other cases, the person was removed from the community.

Exodus 31:1–11

God gave instructions for the tabernacle complex and for those who would serve in it. He also chose and empowered those who would do the work.

Exodus 31:3

I have filled him with the Spirit of God: This is one of the earliest references to being filled with the Spirit as an expression of divine empowerment for

activities that are clearly beyond normal human abilities (see also [Genesis 41:38](#); [Numbers 11:17](#); [Judges 6:34](#); [14:19](#); [1 Samuel 10:6](#); [16:13](#); [Joel 2:28–29](#); [Micah 3:8](#)).

Exodus 31:6

God gave detailed and remarkable instructions. He also provided skilled craftsmen who could complete the work exactly as he commanded.

In this way, God supplied what his people needed to obey him. This idea is similar to a prayer by Augustine in his book *Confessions*: “Give what you command, and command what you will” (10.29). Augustine meant that God must give people the ability to do what he requires.

Exodus 31:11

The main idea of this whole section ([25:1–40:38](#)) is clear. God wanted to meet his people's need for a visible sign of his presence. They needed something they could see that reminded them that he was with them.

However, this had to be done exactly as God commanded. God set the way his people were to approach him. He determines the terms by which people come to him, not human beings.

Exodus 31:12–18

The Sabbath was understood to be the unique sign of the covenant ([31:13](#), [16](#), [17](#); see also [20:8–11](#); [Isa 58:13–14](#); [Jer 17:21–27](#); [Neh 13:15–22](#)). The Sabbath is also said to figure significantly in the achievement of God's underlying purpose of making his people holy, that is, set apart for his exclusive use and sharing his character ([Exod 31:13](#), [14](#), [15](#)). Resting from their own work ([31:15](#), [17](#)) was also a practical way of demonstrating genuine dependence on God to meet their needs (see [20:8–11](#) and study notes).

Exodus 31:14–15

It is absolutely important to learn that we can find life in God only by coming to him in his way. This is underlined by the death sentence for disobedience (see also [Num 15:32–36](#)). This is not to say that

followers of God must always punish those who commit these offenses in this way; but here at the outset, it was vital to make this truth clear (see [Acts 5:1-11](#)). If the spiritual truth of this lesson has not been learned, mere ritual obedience will be of no value (see [Col 2:16-19](#)).

Exodus 31:18

Normally, each party to a covenant received a written copy of the terms of the covenant. So it may be that the two stone tablets were identical, one being God's copy and the other the people's copy, to be kept together in the Ark of the Covenant. • finger of God: See [34:28](#).

Exodus 32:1

The Israelites' actions were motivated by fear, disrespect for this fellow Moses, disbelief in God's leadership, and denial of responsibility. They were unwilling to wait for God to reveal his plans of care for them. Refusal to wait on God is often a cause of sin (see [1 Sam 13:7-13](#); [Isa 30:15-18](#)).

Exodus 32:1-6

The people were not willing to wait and see what God had been saying to Moses on the mountain for the forty days while he was there (see [24:18](#)).

Exodus 32:1-35

At the foot of Mount Sinai, after Moses had been absent for many days, the people felt the need for protection, guidance, and a tangible way to express their worship. God knew this and was eager to meet these needs (chs [25-31](#)). The Israelites, however, tried to meet their needs for themselves. Fellowship with God requires depending on him (see [John 15:5](#); [2 Cor 3:5](#)).

Exodus 32:2-4

The religious professional, Aaron, demanded a specific contribution of gold rings and then excluded the people from any further involvement in the process. This is very different from what God had commanded regarding the construction of the

Tabernacle, where the people were invited to bring many different kinds of things as they felt led ([25:1-9](#); [35:4-36:7](#)) and to share in the work under the guidance of a Spirit-filled layperson ([31:1-6](#); [36:1-2](#)).

Exodus 32:4

- *fashioned it into a molten calf*: The idol might have been a bull, similar to the Egyptian god Amon-Re, which the people knew from Egypt. The bull represented power, domination, and fertility. The writer might have said calf to despise the idol. Or, Aaron might have made a calf, thinking this sin was less severe than making a full-sized bull.
- *These, O Israel, are your gods, who brought you up out*: The people credited the idol with what they had just said Moses did ([32:1](#)). Idolatry shows the belief that the divine and visible worlds are continuous. This view suggests one can access divine power by manipulating the god through the idol. God insisted the opposite is true. God's creation cannot contain or limit him. No one can receive his blessing by manipulating creation, either in a ceremony or otherwise. God's blessings are for those who give up their own efforts to feel secure and come to him in the ways he has revealed.

Exodus 32:5

- Aaron tried to manage the process, but he gave up leadership by simply doing what he thought people wanted.
- Although Aaron called the idol "your gods" ([32:4](#)), he also suggested it was a physical manifestation of the Lord.

Exodus 32:6

The Hebrew term translated as *indulge in revelry* is traditionally translated as *they got up to play*. In Hebrew, like in English, the word *play* can imply sexual activities (see [Genesis 26:8](#), “caressing”). This is likely the case here.

Worship of a fertility symbol, such as a bull, often included the worshipers engaging in sexual activities (see [1 Corinthians 10:7–8](#)).

Exodus 32:7

your people, whom you brought up out of the land of Egypt: Here God attributes his own work to Moses. This suggests God was testing Moses, giving him a chance to avoid the same mistake the people made ([32:1](#)). God was not tempting Moses to do wrong (see [James 1:13–14](#)). But he placed Moses in a situation with a clear choice that could lead in different directions (compare [1 Kings 22:19–23](#)).

Exodus 32:9–10

God was apparently ready to reject his people. They had broken their covenant (their binding agreement) with him.

Exodus 32:10

- *Now leave me alone*: This sounded like a command, but it was actually an invitation. God was giving Moses an opportunity to pray for the people. Moses was to stand before God as an intercessor (a person who speaks to God on behalf of others). The people deserved to be destroyed because of their sin. However, God was willing to spare them if Moses continued to pray for them.
- *I will make you into a great nation*: God told Moses that he could begin again with him alone. God could abandon the other descendants of Abraham and build a new nation from the children of Moses. This was likely a test. It showed whether Moses understood God's character and his promises.

Exodus 32:11–13

If there was a test, Moses passed it. He refused to take God's place ([32:11](#)). He knew God is just and faithful and would not save people just to destroy them ([32:12](#)). He declined the offer to become the father of a great nation because it would mean God violating promises to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob ([32:13](#)). Moses understood who God truly is.

Exodus 32:14

In response to the argument of Moses, the Lord changed his mind.

This does not show God as an angry ruler who must be forced to calm down. The Bible does not present him as a tyrant who is difficult to persuade.

Instead, the Lord is more willing to show mercy than to bring punishment. He invites those who are close to him, like Moses, to pray and speak on behalf of others.

Through faithful intercession (prayer on behalf of someone else), God gives an opportunity for mercy.

Exodus 32:15-29

When Moses saw what was happening, he became much less calm than he was on the mountain. He smashed the two tablets ([32:15-19](#)). He destroyed the calf ([32:20](#)). He confronted Aaron ([32:21-25](#)). He ordered the death of the rebellious leaders ([32:26-29](#)).

Exodus 32:16

The tablets were the work of God: The covenant was more than just a human agreement.

Exodus 32:19

Moses might have shattered the tablets out of anger. It could also have been his way of saying the people shattered the covenant with God. Later, God reminded Moses that he was the one who broke the tablets (see [34:1](#)).

Exodus 32:20

Passing the gold powder of the image through the bodies of the people effectively rendered it unclean.

Exodus 32:21-25

Aaron denied responsibility, even though he made the molds and poured the gold ([32:4](#)). Aaron wanted Moses to believe it all just happened ([32:24](#)). He implied he had no choice because the people were so evil ([32:22](#)).

Aaron did not fool Moses. Moses knew Aaron could have led the people, but instead, he allowed them to get completely out of control ([32:25](#)).

Exodus 32:25

a laughingstock to their enemies: After the Israelites' great show of worshiping the Lord as a different kind of God, their actions proclaimed that he was merely another of the idols that their enemies had been worshiping all along (see [Ezekiel 36:19-20](#)).

Exodus 32:26-29

Moses had asked God to spare the people, but now he called on those who followed the Lord to kill those who had sinned. The Levites ([32:26](#)) were willing to confront the sin that Aaron had let loose. Although Moses commanded them to kill everyone ([32:27](#)), the number 3,000 ([32:28](#)) makes it clear that the words *each of you* had a restricted meaning.

The reference to *his son and his brother* suggests that as Aaron had led in the idolatry, many of the Levites had led in the worship of the idol, and they were the ones that the rest of the Levites killed. Aaron may have escaped because God had already designated him as high priest ([28:1](#)).

Exodus 32:30-35

This further intercession for the people may have been needed because of the new recognition Moses had of how serious the sin really was.

Exodus 32:32

Earlier, God had offered to make Moses into a great nation instead of the people. Moses had refused that offer.

Here, Moses again showed his loyalty to the people. He asked God to destroy him also if God chose not to forgive them.

Exodus 32:33

God did not grant what Moses requested. Instead, God said he would judge only those who had sinned in that event.

Exodus 32:34

- *the place I described:* This refers to Canaan, which God promised to give to Abraham's descendants (see [3:17](#); [32:13](#); [33:1](#)).
- *on the day I settle accounts:* Because of God's mercy, judgment may not always come immediately. But in this instance, God soon sent a plague ([32:35](#)). Judgment will come for those who continue to sin (see [Matthew 13:24-30](#)).

Exodus 33:1-6

God would not lead the people up to Canaan as he had previously led them (see [33:3](#); but also [33:14-17](#)). Instead, he would send an angel ([33:2](#)).

Exodus 33:2-3

- *an angel ... But I will not go with you:* This *angel* might not be the "angel of the LORD," since in Exodus and other parts of the Old Testament, the angel of the LORD is closely associated with God's presence (see [3:2](#); [23:20-23](#)). Or, God might have meant that while he would lead them through the angel ([33:2](#)), he would not live among them in the tabernacle as planned ([33:3](#)).
- *Canaanites ... Jebusites:* See study note on 3:8.

Exodus 33:3

- *land flowing with milk and honey:* Canaan was not as fertile as the Nile Valley in Egypt, but it was much more productive than the Sinai desert.
- *stiff-necked people:* They did not keep their promises.
- *I might destroy you:* As God of the covenant, the Lord would enforce the covenant terms that required the destruction of those who violated it (see study note on 23:20-33; also see [24:7-8](#) and study notes).

Exodus 33:4-6

People might have worn jewelry and fine clothes while worshiping the gold calf. Removing them here shows mourning and repentance ([33:4](#)).

Exodus 33:7

The tabernacle is often called the *Tent of Meeting* (see study note on 27:21). In many passages, these two expressions refer to the same structure.

However, in this passage, the *Tent of Meeting* refers to a different, temporary tent. Moses set up this tent outside the camp before the tabernacle was built.

Later, when the tabernacle was completed, it was placed in the center of the camp (see [Numbers 2:1-31](#)).

Exodus 33:7-11

The way God communicated with his people before the completion of the tabernacle is likely described here. This helps explain the events recorded in [33:1-6](#) and [33:12-23](#).

Exodus 33:8-11

would stand ... stand up and bow down: The people considered it amazing that Moses spoke directly to God, "face to face" ([33:11](#)).

Exodus 33:11

Joshua had earlier gained experience as a military leader (see [17:9-13](#)). Now, he was gaining experience as a spiritual leader (see also [24:13](#)). He may have stayed behind to guard the tent, a function the Levites would later fulfill with the tabernacle ([1 Chronicles 26](#)).

Exodus 33:12

I know you by name: God chose Moses himself.

Exodus 33:12-23

Moses begged God to go with him and the people to the promised land. In these verses, the word *Presence* usually translates a Hebrew word that literally means "face" ([33:14-15](#)).

Earlier in the chapter, we learn that the Lord spoke with Moses "face to face" ([33:11](#)). This phrase describes a close and direct relationship. It does not mean that Moses saw God's physical face. It means that God spoke with Moses in a clear and personal way.

Moses wanted that same close relationship to continue. He did not want God to send only an angel or messenger. He wanted God's own presence to go with them. Moses also wanted the people to share in that relationship in some way.

Exodus 33:13

- *please let me know Your ways:* Moses did not just want God's blessings. He wanted to understand God's nature and character. He also wanted to know why and how God acted. God's goal of revealing himself was starting to happen, at least with Moses.
- Moses wanted God to accompany them because they were the Lord's own people.

Exodus 33:14

I will give you rest: Literally *a place to roost*, as in a place where a bird can land and be at peace. Ever since Abraham left Ur, he and his descendants had had no such place.

Exodus 33:15-16

Moses made his request more direct. He showed he understood God's actions. The exodus was not just about leaving Egypt for Canaan. It was about experiencing God personally, which would change their lives. Without this, staying at Mount Sinai would have been better. Going to Canaan without the Lord would be disastrous.

Exodus 33:17

The Lord reaffirmed his agreement to go with them and his personal appointment of Moses.

Exodus 33:18

Moses asked for confirmation of God's promises. He asked to see God's glorious presence (literally *glory*). He was asking for an experience of seeing the very essence of God (see study note on 16:7).

Exodus 33:19

- In his positive reply, God changed the terms of the request Moses made. God promised Moses a glorious experience, but he would not let Moses see his face. In the Old Testament, seeing God's face means seeing God fully and directly. Instead, God said he would show Moses his goodness. He would also proclaim his name. In the Bible, a name often expresses a person's character and identity. God's character is shown especially in his mercy and compassion (see [Romans 9:14-16](#)).
- *the LORD*: In many English Bibles, the word LORD (written in capital letters) stands for the personal name of God, *Yahweh*. In this verse, God emphasizes his personal name. This name shows that he is not distant. He is the covenant God (the God who makes promises) of his people.

Exodus 33:20-23

God desires to reveal his character to his people. However, to see his face means to see his full being (his true and complete nature). No human can see God in this way and live.

God's glorious presence is described in [33:22](#). That kind of direct encounter would bring death to a human person. God allowed Moses to see only a small part of his glory. Moses was given a brief glimpse, but nothing more.

Exodus 34:1-3

God called Moses to come back up Mount Sinai with two new stone tablets. The restrictions for the rest of the people are like those made at first (see [19:12-13](#), [21-25](#)).

Exodus 34:1-35

God granted the request of Moses ([33:18](#)). He showed Moses his goodness ([34:1-9](#)). He renewed the covenant ([34:10-35](#)).

This renewal was a statement made by God alone. God promised to stay with his people, keeping his covenant promises even though they had broken the covenant and deserved death and abandonment ([32:1-6](#)).

Exodus 34:5-6

the LORD: This represents the personal name of God, *Yahweh*. This name appears five times in this passage. By repeating this name, God emphasizes his personal name. This shows that he is speaking and acting as the covenant God (the God who makes promises) of his people.

Exodus 34:5-9

Moses experienced God's presence in a revelation of the name, or character, of God. As God had promised ([33:19](#)), he showed Moses the glory of his goodness.

Exodus 34:6

compassion and mercy (see [20:5-6](#); [33:19](#) and study notes): The Creator who was revealing himself to the Israelites, and through them to the world, is a God of grace. Neither his justice nor his sovereignty are underlined here, as true as those attributes are. If God were merely just, the Old Testament would have ended at this point, or it would have picked up and started again with an entirely new family. This did not happen because God, in his unique character, is slow to anger and full of unfailing love and faithfulness. These qualities were the basis for his renewal of the covenant.

Exodus 34:7

God's unfailing love and his generous desire to forgive are not weakness or indecisiveness, nor are they reason to sin. Sin will have its effects, because God created a world of cause and effect. The murderer may repent, be forgiven, and lead a new

life, but the effects of previous choices will continue to play out. We should not sin just because we know that God will forgive (see study note on 20:5-6). • a thousand generations: See [Deut 7:9-11](#). • I lay the sins of the parents: Our sins affect future generations of descendants, but God restricts the natural effect of those sins to three or four generations. See also [Exod 20:5-6](#).

Exodus 34:8-9

Since the Lord had already twice promised to go with them ([33:14, 17](#)), this renewed request seems to show a lack of faith. It may also be that God's presence had driven home to Moses how absolutely holy God is and how very different he is from this stubborn and rebellious people. Here Moses took his request a step further and asked God to travel with the people and make them his own special possession (see [19:5-6](#)). Moses asked for the complete restoration of the relationship.

Exodus 34:10-11

God promised to miraculously care for his people as he brought them into Canaan. This care depended on their obedience. In Hebrew, the word translated as *observe* also means "obey" ([34:11](#)). Unlike English, Hebrew does not separate hearing a command from obeying it.

Exodus 34:10-26

Some of the terms of the covenant are restated, particularly those that prohibit the worship of other gods and that describe the proper worship of the Lord.

Exodus 34:12-17

Worship of idols was prohibited, particularly the idols of the peoples into whose lands the Israelites were going. Central to this restriction was the prohibition of treaties, or covenants, with these idol-worshipping peoples. Not only would the making of a treaty involve recognizing those peoples' gods (because ancient treaties would call upon the gods as witnesses; see study note on 20:1-23:33), but the very existence of the treaties

would predispose the Israelites to accept the ways of their treaty partners ([34:12, 15-16](#)).

Exodus 34:13

Asherah was a Canaanite fertility goddess who would continue to be a temptation throughout Israel's history (see, e.g., [Judg 6:25](#); [1 Kgs 14:15](#); [2 Kgs 23:15](#)). • The poles seem to have been fertility symbols.

Exodus 34:16

Marriage with people who worshiped other gods was a problem throughout the Old Testament. God warned His people not to marry those who followed other gods (see [Genesis 24:3](#); [Ezra 9:1-2](#); compare [2 Corinthians 6:14-18](#)).

Exodus 34:22

Feast of Ingathering: See study notes on 23:16; Leviticus 23:15-21, 34-43.

Exodus 34:23

three times: See [23:14-17](#).

Exodus 34:24

no one will covet your land: If Israel would trust God and obey him, he would protect them.

Exodus 34:27-28

Moses wrote down these repeated instructions that explained the main terms of the covenant ([34:27](#)).

The Ten Commandments, which summarize these terms, were written on the new stone tablets ([34:28](#)).

Exodus 34:29-35

Moses, who had asked to see the glory of God, was not aware that his own face reflected that glory.

Exodus 34:33

he put a veil over his face: While Moses was reporting what God had said to him, he left his face unveiled. Then he covered it, perhaps because of the fear its brightness caused during normal conversation ([34:30](#); see [2 Corinthians 3:7-18](#) for the apostle Paul's thoughts on this event).

Exodus 35:1-40:38

Much of the report of the building of the Tabernacle reiterates what was said in [25:1-31:18](#). There is a change from the imperative mood to the indicative, and there are certain changes in the order. This repetition underlines the point that the work was done exactly as God had commanded (see [40:16](#)). The people had tried to secure God's presence in their own way with the gold calf, and the result was disaster. Now they were doing it in God's way, resulting in blessing ([40:34-38](#)).

Exodus 35:4-36:7

Unlike the creation of the gold calf, where Aaron demanded that one type of material (earrings) be given (see study note on [32:2-4](#)), the people were again invited to bring a variety of gifts ([35:4-9](#)) as their hearts were stirred and their spirits were moved ([35:21](#)). Perhaps because the variety of gifts meant that everyone could bring something and because the giving was voluntary, the people gave too much and had to be commanded to stop ([36:4-7](#)).

Exodus 37:1-29

While it is said that Bezalel made the Ark and all the rest of the furnishings ([37:1](#), [10](#), [17](#), [25](#)) as well as the courtyard and its furnishings ([38:1](#), [8](#), [9](#), [18](#)), this is probably only a way of saying that he was responsible and directed the other craftsmen and seamstresses.

Exodus 38:1-20

This section reports on building the courtyard ([38:9-20](#)) and its equipment, including the altar of burnt offering and the bronze basin ([38:1-7](#); [38:8](#)).

Exodus 38:8

- The plans for the bronze basin were part of the instructions to the priests ([30:17-21](#); [29:38-30:38](#)). Here, however, the text reports how the basin was built, following a logical order.
- This bronze, which they could polish to look like mirrors, was probably of very high quality. It was suitable for use in God's Tent of Meeting.

Exodus 38:21

Since the tabernacle contained the ark of the covenant (also called the ark of the Testimony), it is called the *tabernacle of the Testimony*.

Exodus 38:21-29

The very large amount of metal listed here includes more than one metric ton (about 1,000 kilograms) of gold, almost four metric tons (about 4,000 kilograms) of silver, and two and a half metric tons (about 2,500 kilograms) of bronze.

This large supply shows how eager the Egyptians were to send the Israelites away. The Egyptians gave the Israelites whatever they asked for so that they would leave quickly (see [12:35-36](#)).

Exodus 38:26

- For the earlier discussion of this tax, see [30:11-16](#). The *sanctuary shekel* was the standard used to measure other weights accurately.
- *603,550*: See study note on [12:37](#).

Exodus 39:1–31

See [Exodus 28:1–43](#).

Exodus 39:30

The term *holy crown* might be a formal title. The initial description of the plate in [28:36](#) does not include that term.

Exodus 39:32–43

Moses inspected the finished work and confirmed that everything had been done just as the Lord had commanded ([39:43](#)). As a result, Moses blessed them instead of pronouncing judgment upon them, as when they had tried to meet their need for God's presence in their own ways ([32:27](#)).

Exodus 40:1–33

The report on setting up the Tabernacle begins with the Lord's commands to do so ([40:1–15](#)) and continues with the report on how Moses obeyed those commands ([40:16–33](#)). • The repeated statement that Moses did everything just as the Lord had commanded him ([40:16](#), [19](#), [21](#), [23](#), [25](#), [27](#), [29](#), [32](#)) is in radical contrast to Aaron's self-serving statement in [32:22–24](#). God wishes to share his presence with us, but his holiness is such that this can occur only if we renounce our own efforts to secure his presence and gifts.

Exodus 40:2

In the Tabernacle, the divine King met with Israel to communicate his will to them. • the first day of the new year: The Tabernacle was set up one year after God announced the Passover and the start of Israel's calendar.

Exodus 40:3

The Hebrew word translated Covenant is 'eduth ("testimony"), which refers particularly to the covenant stipulations. The written copy of these stipulations contained in the Ark would serve as a testimony to the covenant Israel had entered into with God.

Exodus 40:33

So Moses finished the work: This statement marks the completion of the work on the tabernacle. The long process of building and preparing all its parts had now come to an end. See study note on [37:1–29](#).

Exodus 40:34–38

The climax of the Exodus occurred when the glory of the Lord filled the Tabernacle. God's goal from the outset was not merely to deliver his people from their bondage, but to bring them into a relationship with himself. Their real need was to know God personally in their lives. Without that, the Promised Land would not be a land of promise. Now it would be, because the glory that had been on Mount Sinai was in Israel's midst; it would not be left behind but would travel with them wherever they might go.

Exodus 40:38

the whole family of Israel: This description is reminiscent of the way the book began (see [1:1–7](#)). Jacob's family had become slaves in Egypt. What a dramatic change had occurred! They were no longer slaves. They were now in a position to be a blessing to the earth, as God had promised to Abraham generations earlier ([Gen 12:3](#)).